

REVISED ANNOTATED LYSISTRATA WITH GUIDE TO SPIKE LEE'S CHIRAQ



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Revised Annotated Lysistrata

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Critical Introduction and Discussion Guide

Aristophanes' *Lysistrata*: An Introduction, by Jessalynn Bird

Aristophanes and His Career

A contemporary of Socrates (469-399 BCE) and Plato (c. 429-347 BCE), Aristophanes (Air-is-TAH-fah-knees) was a citizen of Athens. Plato's *Symposium*, as we will see, describes him as the life of the party and unapologetically heterosexual (in contrast to some of the other participants). He was a prolific writer, authoring over 40 plays. Eleven survive and offer an unique opportunity for readers to try to understand the political nature of comedic plays in Athens in the fifth century BCE. Aristophanes' own perspective is difficult to summarize, but he skewered contemporary politics and social institutions (a bit like *The Daily Show*, *Colbert Report*, or *Saturday Night Live*) and was hauled into court twice by the demagogue Cleon. He was particularly preoccupied with the effects of the Peloponnesian War (431-404 BCE) and *Lysistrata* was written and produced at a time when Athens was not faring particularly well in that conflict and some parties longed for peace.

Greek Drama in Athens

Greek theater's origins were indebted to the political and religious climate of Athens. Long before Aristophanes was born, the tyrant Pisistratus established a new holiday, The Great Dionysia, to complement another festival, the Lenaea, already dedicated to Dionysus, god of wine. These festivals included the staging of plays. Greek drama had evolved within a religious context, from humans acting out mythic narratives told by a chorus with songs, speeches and dance, all to honor a particular god (in this case Dionysus). There were three main types of plays: tragedies, comedies, and satyr plays. Playwrights would contribute plays to the festivals in the hopes of winning prizes (we don't know which award *Lysistrata* might have received).

In Athens, the wealthy were subject to special taxes, including being chosen to sponsor one of the plays required for these festivals. Once chosen, the sponsor was responsible for selecting the writer and financially underwriting the entire production. Similar to Romans competing with each other to put on lavish spectacles in order to win the political support of the people, so too wealthy Athenians sought to earn political capital through supporting a government-sponsored religious festival attended by every male citizen in Athens (we do not know how many, if any, women attended). The plays were judged by a jury and substantial prizes were awarded.

Imagine a modern comedian lampooning a prominent political figure live, with that person sitting in the front row; that is what Aristophanes' plays did with leading power players in Athens. Aristophanes did not hesitate to criticize entire social groups or to "get personal" with attacks on individuals' life, family, and public and private conduct. And he seems to have gotten away with his indictments of particular individuals and the system itself because he did so in the name of the public good, the benefit of the very audience attending and the individuals and state funding his plays.

What about the logistics of productions? The surviving ruins of the [Theater of Dionysos in Athens](#) give us some sense of the struggles ancient producers faced; the seats are distant from the dancing floor and stage and there was no artificial lighting, curtain or sound system. Most props were probably hand-held. Actors were all men and sometimes played multiple roles in the same play. Comedies in particular involved an element of burlesque or circus-like atmosphere with stylized and exaggerated masks, costumes, and slapstick humor similar to techniques utilized by professional wrestlers or circus clowns. Unlike the formalized and solemn declamations and dance of Greek tragedy (similar to Japanese Noh plays), Greek comedy was fast-moving and bawdy.

Similarly, while tragedies strove for the universal, dealt with the cosmic events decreed by fate, and stimulated powerful emotions to evoke *catharsis*, comedy relied on reacting to contemporary events. In tragedy, a prominent but imperfect individual comes to a sticky end through a personal flaw or unfortunate action. Sometimes this tragedy engulfs other members of the family or society itself. In contrast, in comedy, a relatively unknown character takes charge and brings resolution from chaos. The roles of the chorus also differed. In tragedy the chorus' comments reflect social norms and values; in comedy, the chorus represents the fringe.

Democracy in Athens

In *Lysistrata*, arguments about the functioning and purpose of democracy are fundamental. The play opens with women, who would never in real life be allowed to attend the Athenian General Assembly, forming an assembly of their own under their demagogic leader, Lysistrata. Their assembly storms and defends the Acropolis from a counterattack by the chorus of old men, who suspect a coup by a special interest group (the opinions of the old men represent those who had originally urged on the Peloponnesian War). The Councillor, part of a government board, tries to make peace by accusing the male Assembly which voted for the attack on Sicily (this Assembly consisted of all male citizens, including those with a vested interest in continuing the war). Myrrhine's husband, Cinesias, then meets the Spartan ambassador and brings him and the Athenian ambassadors to the Council of Five Hundred instead. Lysistrata successfully guides the bargaining there and, peace made, a feast follows.

Shortly after *Lysistrata* was performed, popular government was suppressed by a real oligarchic coup--the Fourth Hundred seized dictatorial control (supported by Athenian factions and Persian and Spartan infiltrators). By 411 BCE, Theramenes favored making peace with Sparta after Athens won the Battle of Cyzicus in 410 BCE. However, the demagogue Cleophon, backed by a "hawkish radical democracy" seized control and the war dragged on. After Athens lost the war in 404 BCE, the Spartan-backed regime ruled with an iron fist (the climate of fear under Critias and his cronies, who targeted democrats and moderates, is sketched out in the materials on Neaira).

The excesses and potentials of Athenian democracy were weighed by the founders of this country, but the government of the United States was and is far different than that of 5th century BCE Athens. Thank heavens it is. But in comparison to the leadership style described in *The Iliad* and *The Odyssey*, Athens' government as a city-state was a vast improvement and Athenians were highly invested in it. Pericles' famous speech on those who perished during the Persian Wars implied that what made Athens special was worth dying for. Athenians venerated Draco as their first lawgiver, while Solon dealt with a faltering economy by erasing debt and encouraging trade. He also widened the possibility of holding both high and low government positions to new groups by stressing a certain level of income rather than family ancestry. Even citizens with no income could participate in the Assembly. His reforms led to temporary anarchy and the rule of a tyrant, Pisistratus. A Greek "tyrant" was a different creature than a twenty-first century "tyrant". Their rule was generally short-lived and consisted of executive wielding of emergency powers. They were often demagogues, that is, deriving their powers from promising to serve the interests of the common people. Pisistratus claimed to represent the urban poor and impoverished farmers and preferred to work within existing institutional forms. He redistributed land and encouraged Athenians to extend their power through war, colonies, and trade.

After another period of uncertainty, Cleisthenes reformed the very government of Athens in 508/507 BCE. The Council of Four Hundred had received one hundred men from each ancient Ionian tribe, leading to factionalism. Instead, Cleisthenes created new tribes based on groups of administrative areas (*demes*): one from the coast, one from the inland, and one from the city proper. Fifty men from each tribe composed a new Council of Five Hundred. Each fifty took one-tenth of the year to serve as the Prytany Council. Shortly thereafter, each tribe elected one general each and soon one-commander-in-chief was chosen as well. All these choices appear to have been by lottery. Ostracism served as another check to the ambitious. Citizens could vote for the ten-year exile of any citizen they wished by writing their name on a pottery shard (*ostraka*). Under Ephialtes and Pericles, the Council of the Areopagus, dominated by aristocrats, had its powers curbed to the consideration of homicide and serious crimes, while all other cases fell to the popular court of the Assembly. Pericles introduced pay for all officeholders, including those who served on juries and promoted the expansion of the Athenian empire to prop up domestic spending on welfare programs and building campaigns, including the Parthenon.

This ever-evolving system of government was consistently tested by critics and elitist factions who continued to exercise power, mostly outside the government, because Athenian democracy deliberately sought to limit their participation and kept office-holding stints by in large short, by lottery, and without formal training (unlike the Romans). Charismatic and well-spoken individuals could cultivate power by giving speeches in Assembly and prosecuting opponents in court. Influence could also be wielded by access to private or state money. Salaries for elected offices were essential (otherwise no one would want to or be able to serve), yet corruption and pork-barreling were also widespread. In particular, law courts paid jurors for their time and individuals appear to have brought lawsuits as a means to intimidate rivals, obtain influence and revenge. Sycophants--men who looked out for any kind of infraction in order to prosecute an individual in court (and obtain a reward) or extort money from their victim, created a semi-professional and deeply unscrupulous class of informants and public prosecutors (see Stephanus in the trial of Neaira). Moreover, the Athenian police were more like public bodyguards responsible for ensuring the physical safety of officials and keeping order at public festivals and gatherings. They did not enforce the law and all cases were brought by private individuals. So there was little to

limit self-interest or revenge or encourage the creation of peace, which is what makes the final scenes in *Lysistrata* so startling and surprising.

Greek Warfare

In ancient Athens, war was an omnipresent fact of life. The pictorial symbols for binary gender we still use today derive from this. That for a male represents a shield and spear, that for a woman, a hand-held mirror. Every able-bodied male citizen and even male foreigners (metics) were theoretically required to serve in the army. Families invested in training and equipping men under the age of sixty for military service; it was part of male identity. Aristophanes' attitude towards war was complex. War per se was never condemned outright in Athens, although certain groups had vested interests in negotiation and peace-making. Unlike the United States, in Athens, generals were elected officials and decisions to go to war, how to conduct it, and when to end it were debated and voted on. The Peloponnesian War was controversial from its outset and as a male citizen of Athens, Aristophanes was obliged to offer his opinion. What is daring about *Lysistrata* is that he has Athenian and Spartan women hijack what were traditionally male decisions.

If the *Iliad* and *Odyssey* reflect the world of Mycenaean Greece, it is clear that warriors dominated leadership positions. Wars were often fought over personal matters and by loose conglomerations of individuals bent on obtaining and retaining fame, glory and spoils. Achilles withdraws from joining Agamemnon's forces in battle because his spoils have been confiscated and his honor attacked. Both Achilles and the women of these epic poems are well-aware that life is irreplaceable, the fortunes of war fickle, and the fate of the losers wretched. However, Dark Age Greece saw the rise of colony-building which required sustained military engagement. City-states therefore required their citizens to furnish themselves and train for proficiency in a certain style of fighting. For Athens and Sparta, this was "hoplite" warfare. All middling to upper-range income individuals were required to be ready to serve with shield and spear in phalanx formation. As navies grew in importance, democracy in Athens was expanded to include the less-wealthy, who were required to serve as rowers in trireme ships. These conscript citizen armies were wielded by city-states to appropriate land and engage in what we would consider piracy or banditry.

After the Persian Wars of 490 and 480-79 BCE (most Greeks viewed these as morally just wars protecting the ability of city-states to self-govern against a tyrannical and alien culture), the Delian league of city-states was transformed into the basis of the Athenian sea-based empire. Athens used its navy to demand protection money from the league's members in return for patrolling and controlling sea trade in the eastern Mediterranean. Foreigners were at a disadvantage, in that all disputes were settled in Athenian courts. These foreigners included other Greeks, some of whom turned to Sparta for leadership, eventually sparking the Peloponnesian Wars. These wars became in a sense, proxy wars, as Athens and Sparta fought through their allies and other states and ethnic groups quickly became embroiled in a long-running and ugly conflict which resembled, in many ways, a civil war complete with atrocities and meddling in the internal politics of rival city-states (431-404 BCE).

Women in Athens

Aristophanes' play is a commentary, partly, on the status of women in Athens. What then, was the life of an Athenian woman like? Most representations of women from this period are created by male artists and portray women as naturally prone to violence and promiscuity and thus needing to be physically and mentally restrained, a view voiced by *Lysistrata* when she mimics a man declaiming "women are capable of anything." As you have read in the article about Greek men and the *oikos* (household), most Athenian citizen males married much younger teenage women whom they viewed as needing to be "broken in" and carefully watched in order to avoid illegitimate children and the wastage of household resources. For many males, rigid parameters and roles were considered necessary. An unmarried woman was a tragedy, and marriage the solution to female biological, moral, and intellectual weakness.

Xenophon's famous treatise on how to manage an estate famously depicts a male character laying out the duties of his wife (fifteen at the time of their marriage). Brought up under strict supervision so she would "see, hear, and say as little as possible," she claims that the only things she has learned from her mother are that she must preserve her chastity and how to produce woolen textiles. Her husband therefore instructs her on how to manage the household resources and supervise the slaves working for her. This is clearly male fantasy, but the fantasy is revealing. Better a blank slate than a cunning woman full of tricks and stratagems.

If upper class wives were necessary evils for the production of legitimate heirs and management of the household, their identities and roles were to remain bound to that private world. Pericles' famous speech reminds women that it is a compliment for their names not to be publicly known. Respectable women were identified by their male relatives ("the wife of Socrates," "the daughter of Lysurgus"). In contrast, *Lysistrata* is filled with the names of women precisely because they are doing what "good" women

should not -- entering into the public sphere. Respectable upper-class women confined themselves to the women's quarters within the home except for certain public religious festivals and rites and visits to other women. If they appeared on the street, they were veiled and accompanied by slaves and/or chaperones. These restrictions, of course, could not apply to female slaves and women from the poorer classes, as we have and will see from other sources.

Because upper-class women were confined to the home, apart from textile production and children, they were reduced to being consumers rather than producers. And yet to be taken seriously, an Athenian citizen had to be married. The result? A proliferation of misogynistic (anti-woman) literature. Relationships with other males confirmed and strengthened a male's masculinity whereas spending too much time with women might make him "effeminate," or uxorious (dominated by his wife) as in the case of Paris in *The Iliad*.

To make matters worse, Athenians determined eligibility for citizenship based on lineage. Pericles sponsored a law, in 451/450 BCE, that citizenry would be restricted to the legitimate children of two Athenian citizens. This law in a sense aided Athenian women by preventing Athenian men from marrying foreigners, but also resulted in thousands of individuals claiming Athenian citizenship being convicted of "fraud" and sold as slaves. How could one prove citizenship without documentation? How could prove the legitimacy of a child without DNA testing? We will see these issues explored in the trial of Neaira. In contrast, the city-state of Sparta was organized along communal lines; adultery and legitimacy lost much of their meaning if children were surrendered to the state.

Athenian women sacrificed freedoms in return for a tenuous security; Athenian men must marry them to produce citizen heirs and the government provided primitive forms of social security such as providing dowries for poor female citizens, supporting widows and orphans (numerous due to disease and war), and passing laws which ensured that women could not be completely abandoned (such as those requiring males who inherited a deceased males' property having to marry his widow). Athenian citizen women jealously guarded their prerogatives against foreign women and female slaves and prostitutes. Their imagined concerns in time of war are highlighted in *Lysistrata*. Athenian comedy depended on a carnivalesque model of the world turned upside down; that women must appear in public and create peace is a condemnation of Athenian men rather than an encomium to the capabilities of women. *Lysistrata* also highlights the near monopoly women had in certain religious festivals and rites woven into the political and religious life of the city-state.

READING QUESTIONS:

THROUGHOUT THE PLAY:

By what methods do Lysistrata and her band of protestors hope to stop the war? Would we use these methods today? Why/why not?

We will be watching Spike Lee's *Chirag*, an adaptation of *Lysistrata* set in besieged African-American communities in Chicago. Imagine what changes he might need or want to make as you read through the play (but don't watch the movie yet!).

In what other contexts (historical or modern) could you imagine *Lysistrata* being staged? What other conflicts might be addressed through women (or another politically disenfranchised group) taking charge?

How do the actions taken by the women in *Lysistrata* compare to recent forms of protest in the #MeToo and #BlackLivesMatter movements? What about the reactions of those in power?

SECTION 1:

Go to section 1 of *Lysistrata* (2.1).

In section 1, what kinds of male assumptions and stereotypes about women are voiced by Lysistrata and her comrades (who are being played by male actors in female clothing)? List them out.

In section 1, the translator chose to give the Spartans a stereotypical Scottish "brogue," claiming it reflects the "shrewd, canny, uncouth Scottish highlander of modern times." What dangers lie in this approach? How might an American translator signal the

differences between Sparta and Athens by the way Lampito speaks? What dangers and advantages come from the option you proposed?

What kinds of religious activities did Greek women participate in and why might this have made section 1 so funny for a Greek male audience?

SECTION 2:

Go to section 2 of *Lysistrata* (2.2).

What is meant to be so funny about the clash between the chorus of Old Men and that of the Old Women? Is it important that it takes place on the Acropolis? Why/why not?

The Magistrate's speech compares and contrasts the roles of men and women in Athens: what are they? Compare Lysistrata's speech on the same topic towards the end of section 2.

What criticisms and insights are being offered in section 2 about the nature of war? Would they transfer to modern conflicts? Why/why not?

Section 2 also deals with status and position. How do individuals rank themselves and claim authority and/or rights?

What problems might arise from using Scythians to maintain public order (see the notes for section 2)? Have we seen similar criticisms about police forces in our country?

SECTION 3:

Go to section 3 of *Lysistrata* (2.3).

The two choruses of men and women stake competing claims as to who has sacrificed and served Athens and who deserves benefits from and a say in its government. List out these competing arguments.

Lysistrata voices Greek attitudes towards the nature of women--what are these attitudes? Do the actions of the female protesters confirm or contrast with these views?

The Old Man and the Old Woman both reinterpret existing legends to prove their points. How do they adapt these legends and what point are they trying to make? Do we do this with our own history?

SECTION 4:

Go to section 4 of *Lysistrata* (2.4).

There is an important exchange between Cinesias and Myrrhine. What Greek attitudes towards marriage and family does their exchange illustrate? List them out and explain how they are similar to or different from 21st century attitudes towards family and marriage.

What does Myrrhine want Cinesias to do? How does she persuade him to do it? Would women use similar methods of persuasion today? Why/why not?

The magistrate meets a Spartan herald. What does their exchange tell us about stereotypes? Peace negotiations?

SECTION 5:

Go to section 5 of *Lysistrata* (2.5)

Why does the exchange between the old man and old woman begin this section? Are the differences between men and women in Athens more or less reconcilable than those between Athens and Sparta?

The chorus gives us a glimpse into the workings of Athenian politics at the beginning and end of section 5. What information about various motives for the war can we extract from the chorus' speech?

Lysistrata takes the floor as arbitrator with Reconciliation. How do the two lead the Spartans and ambassadors to peace? What arguments do they present? How might this part of the play be staged and/or performed?

SECTION 6:

Go to section 5 of *Lysistrata* (2.5)

Aristophanes is at time and has to wrap the play. Given the rest of the play, is this ending satisfying? Why/why not?

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Translation of Lysistrata

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2.1: Section 1

The Persons of the drama.

LYSISTRATA

CALONICE

MYRRHINE

LAMPITO

Stratyllis, etc.

Chorus of Women.

MAGISTRATE

CINESIAS

SPARTAN HERALD

ENVOYS

ATHENIANS

Porter, Market Idlers, etc.

Chorus of old Men.

LYSISTRATA [1] (She stands alone with the Propylaea [2] at her back).

LYSISTRATA

If they were trysting for a Bacchanal [3],

A feast of Pan [4] or Colias [5] or Genetyllis, [6]

The tambourines would block the rowdy streets,

But now there's not a woman to be seen

Except--ah, yes--this neighbor of mine over there.

(Enter CALONICE). [7]

Good day, Calonice.

CALONICE

Good day, Lysistrata.

But what has vexed you so? Tell me, child.

What are these black looks for? It doesn't suit you

To knit your eyebrows up glumly like that.

LYSISTRATA

Calonice, it's more than I can bear,

I am hot all over with blushes for our sex.

Men say we're slippery rogues--

CALONICE

And aren't they right?

LYSISTRATA

Yet summoned on the most tremendous business

For deliberation, still they snuggle in bed.

CALONICE

My dear, they'll come. It's hard for women, you know,

To get away. There's so much to do;

Husbands to be patted and put in good tempers:

Servants to be poked out: children washed

Or soothed with lullays [8] or fed with mouthfuls of pap.

LYSISTRATA

But I tell you, here's a far more weighty object.

CALONICE

What is it all about, dear Lysistrata,
That you've called the women hither in a troop?
What kind of an object is it?

LYSISTRATA

A tremendous thing!

CALONICE

And long?

LYSISTRATA

Indeed, it may be very lengthy.

CALONICE

Then why aren't they here?

LYSISTRATA

No man's connected with it;
If that was the case, they'd soon come fluttering along.
No, no. It concerns an object I've felt over
And turned this way and that for sleepless nights.

CALONICE

It must be fine to stand such long attention.

LYSISTRATA

So fine it comes to this--Greece saved by woman!

CALONICE

By woman? Wretched thing, I'm sorry for it.

LYSISTRATA

Our country's fate is henceforth in our hands:
To destroy the Peloponnesians [9] root and branch--

CALONICE

What could be nobler!

LYSISTRATA

Wipe out the Boeotians--

CALONICE

Not utterly. Have mercy on the eels! [10]

LYSISTRATA

But with regard to Athens, note I'm careful
Not to say any of these nasty things;
Still, thought is free.... But if the women join us
From Peloponnesus and Boeotia, then
Hand in hand we'll rescue Greece. [11]

CALONICE

How could we do
Such a big wise deed? We women who dwell
Quietly adorning ourselves in a back-room
With gowns of lucid gold and gaudy toilets
Of stately silk and dainty little slippers....

LYSISTRATA

These are the very armaments of the rescue.
These crocus-gowns, [12] this outlay of the best myrrh,
Slippers, cosmetics dusting beauty, and robes
With rippling creases of light.

CALONICE

Yes, but how?

LYSISTRATA

No man will lift a lance against another--

CALONICE

I'll run to have my tunic dyed crocus.

LYSISTRATA

Or take a shield--

CALONICE

I'll get a stately gown.

LYSISTRATA

Or unscabbard a sword--

CALONICE

Let me buy a pair of slippers.

LYSISTRATA

Now, tell me, are the women right to lag?

CALONICE

They should have turned birds, they should have grown
wings and flown.

LYSISTRATA

My friend, you'll see that they are true Athenians:
Always too late. Why, there's not a woman
From the shoreward *demes* arrived, not one from Salamis. [13]

CALONICE

I know for certain they awoke at dawn,
And got their husbands up if not their boat sails.

LYSISTRATA

And I'd have staked my life the Achamian dames [14]
Would be here first, yet they haven't come either!

CALONICE

Well anyhow there is Theagenes' wife
We can expect--she consulted Hecate. [15]

But look, here are some at last, and more behind them.

See ... where are they from?

CALONICE

From Anagyrā they come. [16]

LYSISTRATA

Yes, they generally manage to come first.

Enter MYRRHINE. [17]

MYRRHINE

Are we late, Lysistrata? ... What is that?

Nothing to say?

LYSISTRATA

I've not much to say for you,

Myrrhine, dawdling on so vast an affair.

MYRRHINE

I couldn't find my girdle in the dark.

But if the affair's so wonderful, tell us, what is it?

LYSISTRATA

No, let us stay a little longer till

The Peloponnesian girls and the girls of Boeotia [18]

Are here to listen.

MYRRHINE

That's the best advice.

Ah, there comes Lampito. [19]

Enter LAMPITO.

LYSISTRATA

Welcome Lampito!

Dear Spartan girl with a delightful face,

Washed with the rosy spring, how fresh you look

In the easy stride of your sleek slenderness,

Why you could strangle a bull! [20]

LAMPITO

I think I could.

It's frae exercise and kicking high behind. [21]

LYSISTRATA

What lovely breasts to own!

LAMPITO

Oo ... your fingers

Assess them, ye tickler, wi' such tender chucks

I feel as if I were an altar-victim. [22]

LYSISTRATA

Who is this youngster?

LAMPITO

A Boeotian lady.

LYSISTRATA

There never was much undergrowth in Boeotia,
Such a smooth place, and this girl takes after it. [23]

CALONICE

Yes, I never saw a skin so primly kept.

LYSISTRATA

This girl?

LAMPITO

A sonsie open-looking jinker! [24]
She's a Corinthian.

LYSISTRATA

Yes, isn't she
Very open, in some ways particularly.

LAMPITO

But who's gathered this Council o' Women to meet here?

LYSISTRATA

I have.

LAMPITO

Propound then what you want o' us.

MYRRHINE

What is the amazing news you have to tell?

LYSISTRATA

I'll tell you, but first answer one small question.

MYRRHINE

As you like.

LYSISTRATA

Are you not sad your children's fathers
Go endlessly off soldiering afar
In this plodding war? I am willing to wager
There's not one here whose husband is at home.

CALONICE

Mine's been in Thrace, keeping an eye on Eucrates [25]
For five months past.

MYRRHINE

And mine left me for Pylos [26]
Seven months ago at least.

LAMPITO

And as for mine
No sooner has he slipped out free of the line
He straps his shield and he's sneaked off again. [27]

LYSISTRATA

And not the slightest glitter of a lover!
And since the Milesians betrayed us, I've not seen
The image of a single upright man
To be a marble consolation to us. [28]
Now will you help me, if I find a means
To stamp the war out.

MYRRHINE

By the two goddesses, yes!
I will though I've to pawn this very dress
And drink the barter-money the same day.

CALONICE

And I too though I'm split up like a turbot [29]
And half is hacked off as the price of peace.

LAMPITO

And I too! Why, to get a peep at the shy thing
I'd clamber up to the tip-top o' Taygetus. [30]

LYSISTRATA

Then I'll expose my mighty mystery.
O women, if we would compel the men
To bow to Peace, we must refrain--

MYRRHINE

From what?
O tell us!

LYSISTRATA

Will you truly do it then?

MYRRHINE

We will, we will, if we must die for it.

LYSISTRATA

We must refrain from every depth of love....
Why do you turn your backs? Where are you going?
Why do you bite your lips and shake your heads?
Why are your faces blanched? Why do you weep?
Will you or won't you, or what do you mean?

MYRRHINE

No, I won't do it. Let the war proceed.

CALONICE

No, I won't do it. Let the war proceed.

LYSISTRATA

You too, dear turbot, you that said just now
You didn't mind being split right up in the least?

CALONICE

Anything else? O bid me walk in fire
But do not rob us of that darling joy.
What else is like it, dearest Lysistrata?

LYSISTRATA

And you?

MYRRHINE

O please give me the fire instead.

LYSISTRATA

Lewd to the least drop in the tiniest vein,
Our sex is fitly food for tragic poets,
Our whole life's but a pile of kisses and babies.
But, hardy Spartan, if you join with me
All may be righted yet. O help me, help me.

LAMPITO

It's a hard, hard thing to ask of us, by the two,
A lass to sleep her alone and never fill
Love's lack except with makeshifts.... But let it be.
Peace must be thought of first.

LYSISTRATA

My friend, my friend!
The only one amid this herd of weaklings.

CALONICE

But if--which heaven forbid--we should refrain
As you would have us, how is Peace induced?

LYSISTRATA

By the two goddesses, now can't you see
All we have to do is idly sit indoors
With smooth roses powdered on our cheeks,
Our bodies burning naked through the folds
Of shining Amorgos' silk, and meet the men
With our dear Venus-plats plucked trim and neat.
Their stirring love will rise up furiously,
They'll beg our arms to open. That's our time!
We'll disregard their knocking, beat them off--
And they will soon be rabid for a Peace.
I'm sure of it.

LAMPITO

Just as Menelaus, they say,
Seeing the bosom of his naked Helen
Flung down the sword. [31]

CALONICE

But we'll be tearful fools
If our husbands take us at our word and leave us.

LYSISTRATA

There's only left then, in Pherecrates' phrase,
"To flay a skinned dog"--flay more our flayed desires. [32]

CALONICE

Bah, proverbs will never warm a celibate.
But what avail will your scheme be if the men
Drag us for all our kicking on to the couch?

LYSISTRATA

Cling to the doorposts.

CALONICE

But if they should force us?

LYSISTRATA

Yield then, but with a sluggish, cold indifference.
There is no joy to them in sullen mating.
Besides we have other ways to madden them;
They cannot stand up long, and they've no delight
Unless we fit their aim with merry succor.

CALONICE

Well if you must have it so, we'll all agree.

LAMPITO

For us I have no doubt. We can persuade
Our men to strike a fair and decent Peace, [33]
But how will you pinch out the battle-frenzy
Of the Athenian populace? [34]

LYSISTRATA

I promise you
We'll wither up that curse.

LAMPITO

I don't believe it.
Not while they own a trireme oared and rigged,
Or have those stacks and stacks and stacks of silver. [35]

LYSISTRATA

I've thought the whole thing out till there's no flaw.
We shall surprise the Acropolis today:
That is the duty set the older dames.
While we sit here talking, they are to go
And under pretense of sacrificing, seize it.

LAMPITO

Sure, that's fine; all's working for the best.

LYSISTRATA

Now quickly, Lampito, let us tie ourselves
To this high purpose as tightly as the hemp of words
Can knot together.

LAMPITO

Set out the terms in detail
And we'll all swear to them. [36]

LYSISTRATA

Of course.... Well then
Where is our Scythianess? [37] Why are you staring?
First lay the shield, boss downward, on the floor
And bring the victim's inwards.

CAILONICE

But, Lysistrata,
What is this oath that we're to swear?

LYSISTRATA

What oath!
In Aeschylus they take a slaughtered sheep [38]
And swear upon a buckler. Why not we?

CALONICE

O Lysistrata, Peace sworn on a buckler!

LYSISTRATA

What oath would suit us then?

CALONICE

Something burden bearing
Would be our best insignia.... A white horse!
Let's swear upon its entrails.

LYSISTRATA

A horse indeed!

CALONICE

Then what will symbolize us?

LYSISTRATA

This, as I tell you--
First set a great dark bowl upon the ground
And disembowel a skin of Thasian wine,
Then swear that we'll not add a drop of water. [39]

LAMPITO

Ah, what oath could clink pleasanter than that!

LYSISTRATA

Bring me a bowl then and a skin of wine.

CALONICE

My dears, see what a splendid bowl it is;
I'd not say "No" if asked to sip it off.

LYSISTRATA

Put down the bowl. Lay hands, all, on the victim.
Holy Queen who gives the last word in arguments,
And thee, O Bowl, dear comrade, we beseech:
Accept our oblation and be propitious to us.

CALONICE

What healthy blood, la, how it gushes out!

LAMPITO

And what a delicious fragrance through the air.

LYSISTRATA

Now, dears, if you will let me, I'll speak first.

CALONICE

Only if you draw the lot, by Aphrodite!

LYSISTRATA

SO, grasp the brim, you, Lampito, and all.

You, Calonice, repeat for the rest

Each word I say. Then you must all take oath

And pledge your arms to the same stern conditions--

LYSISTRATA

To husband or lover I'll not open arms

CALONICE

To husband or lover I'll not open arms.

LYSISTRATA

Though love and denial may enlarge his charms.

CALONICE

Though love and denial may enlarge his charms.

O, O, my knees are failing me, Lysistrata!

LYSISTRATA

But still at home, ignoring him, I'll stay,

CALONICE

But still at home, ignoring him, I'll stay,

LYSISTRATA

Beautiful, clad in saffron silks all day.

CALONICE

Beautiful, clad in saffron silks all day.

LYSISTRATA

If then he seizes me by dint of force,

CALONICE

If then he seizes me by dint of force,

LYSISTRATA

I'll give him reason for a long remorse.

CALONICE

I'll give him reason for a long remorse.

LYSISTRATA

I'll never lie and stare up at the ceiling,

CALONICE

I'll never lie and stare up at the ceiling,

LYSISTRATA

Nor like a lion on all fours go kneeling.

CALONICE

Nor like a lion on all fours go kneeling.

LYSISTRATA

If I keep faith, then bounteous cups be mine.

CALONICE

If I keep faith, then bounteous cups be mine.

LYSISTRATA

If not, to nauseous water change this wine.

CALONICE

If not, to nauseous water change this wine.

LYSISTRATA

Do you all swear to this?

MYRRHINE

We do, we do.

LYSISTRATA

Then I shall immolate the victim thus.

(She drinks).

CALONICE

Here now, share fair, haven't we made a pact?

Let's all quaff down that friendship in our turn.

LAMPITO

Hark, what caterwauling hubbub's that?

LYSISTRATA

As I told you,

The women have appropriated the citadel.

So, Lampito, dash off to your own land [\[40\]](#)

And raise the rebels there. These will serve as hostages,

While we ourselves take our places in the ranks

And drive the bolts right home.

CALONICE

But won't the men

March straight against us?

LYSISTRATA

And what if they do?

No threat shall creak our hinges wide, no torch

Shall light a fear in us; we will come out

To Peace alone.

CALONICE

That's it, by Aphrodite!
As of old let us seem hard and obdurate.

Footnotes:

- [1] Lysistrata means "dissolver of armies."
- [2] The ceremonial gate which led to the top of the Acropolis in Athens.
- [3] Rites in honor of Dionysus (Latin: Bacchus), which often involved copious amounts of drink. The poet Orpheus was supposedly slain by a group of Maenads (female followers of Dionysus) engaged in such rites, either because he neglected to honor Dionysus or spurned their advances. See this contemporary silver vessel depicting Orpheus' death: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Orpheus#/media/File:Kantharos63.9.jpg>
- [4] A rural god often depicted as a satyr.
- [5] Site of a shrine dedicated to Aphrodite, goddess of *eros* or erotic love.
- [6] Goddess of childbirth.
- [7] Calonice means "Beauteous Victory."
- [8] Lullabies.
- [9] They and the Boeotians were part of an alliance against Athens in the Peloponnesian War.
- [10] Boeotian eels were highly esteemed delicacies in Athens.
- [11] Remember Greece was not unified yet, but independent city-states. They are suggesting women from opposing sides unite to bring peace.
- [12] Crocus was a flower whose pollen-bearing stigmas were used to create an expensive saffron (yellow) dye.
- [13] The city-state of Athens included considerable portions of land surrounding it, each divided into a political unit represented in assemblies in Athens. The coast and Salamis were also key areas for military strategy.
- [14] The political unit (*deme*) of Acharnae had seen its inhabitants flee to Athens as refugees before the invading Spartans.
- [15] Hecate was "the goddess of magic, witchcraft, the night, moon, ghosts and necromancy. She was the only child of the Titans Perses and Asteria from whom she received her power over heaven, earth, and sea." See: <https://www.theoi.com/Khthonios/Hekate.html>
- [16] A swampy *deme* of Athens which grew vast quantities of a rank-smelling bush. Greek humor.
- [17] Sarah Ruden translates Myrrhine as "bearded clam" (Ruden 6). More Greek humor.
- [18] Enemies of Athens during the war.
- [19] Lampito means "shining" or "light." She is from Sparta, leader of the coalition opposed to Athens.
- [20] Spartan women exercised in public semi-naked, something considered scandalous for upper class Athenian women.
- [21] "I think I could. / It's free exercise and kicking high behind." Spartan dances often involved jumping and touching heels to derriere. Original translator's footnote: "The translator has put the speech of the Spartan characters in Scotch dialect which is related to English about as was the Spartan dialect to the speech of Athens. The Spartans, in their character, anticipated the shrewd, canny, uncouth Scotch highlander of modern times." The translator here betrays his own biases.
- [22] "Oo ... your fingers / Assess them, you tickler, with such tender knobs / I feel as if I were an altar-victim." Any animal sacrificed to the gods was first examined to ensure it was a perfect physical specimen.
- [23] Athenian women groomed their body hair, sometimes using plucking or burning to do so.
- [24] "A fortunate loose-looking libertine."
- [25] Thrace was a region north of mainland Greece considered semi-barbaric. Nothing certain is known of Eucrates.
- [26] A coastal city occupied by Athens since 425 BCE.

- [27] From this point onwards, I have rendered the Spartan "brogue" into modern English.
- [28] Originally part of the Delian league, the city of Miletus defected in 412 BCE. One of its exports appears, from this comment, to have been dildos.
- [29] A large flat fish a bit like a flounder.
- [30] A mountain near Sparta.
- [31] Helen and Menelaus were Spartans. In one version of what happened after the fall of Troy, Menelaus was about to kill his wife Helen (her elopement with Paris to Troy had caused a ten-year war), when he was overcome by her assets and spared her.
- [32] Perecrates was a comic play-writer.
- [33] The Spartans were infamous for striking hard bargains.
- [34] The phrase here indicates the lower classes who provided rowers for the Athenian navy and tended to support the war as the source for the trade and imperial expansion which underwrote state benefits.
- [35] Heaps of silver. The Athenian acropolis was the site of the Delian league's treasury (a bit like Fort Knox and the federal reserve combined), which funded and was funded by the war.
- [36] What follows is a parody of rituals used to solemnize male oaths.
- [37] Scythians were renowned archers, and male Scythian slaves comprised the state-owned security force in Athens. See: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Skythian_archer_Louvre_F126.jpg
- [38] Aeschylus was a renowned writer of tragic plays. See: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Aeschylus>
- [39] Even in male drinking parties (symposia), wine was mixed with water. Athenian women drank wine at religious festivals and in other contexts, but it would have been diluted. Drunken females were frowned on unless they were prostitutes.
- [40] Sparta.

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2.2: Section 2

(LAMPITO and some go off; the others go up into the Acropolis).

(The Chorus of OLD MEN enter to attack the captured Acropolis).

Make room, Draces, move ahead; why your shoulder's chafed, I see,
With lugging uphill these lopped branches of the olive-tree.
How upside-down and wrong-way-round a long life sees things grow.
Ah, Strymodorus, who'd have thought affairs could tangle so?

The women whom at home we fed,
Like witless fools, with fostering bread,
Have impiously come to this--
They've stolen the Acropolis,
With bolts and bars our orders flout
And shut us out.

Come, Philurgus, bustle thither; lay our branch-bundles on the ground,
In neat stacks beleaguering the insurgents all around;
And the vile conspiratresses, plotters of such mischief dire,
Pile and burn them all together in one vast and righteous pyre:
Fling with our own hands Lycon's wife [1] to fry in the thickest fire.
By Demeter, [2] they'll get no brag while I've a vein to beat!
Cleomenes [3] himself was hurtled out in sore defeat.
His stiff-backed Spartan pride was bent.
Out, stripped of all his arms, he went:
A pigmy cloak that would not stretch
To hide his rump (the draggled wretch),
Six sprouting years of beard, the spilth
Of six years' filth.

That was a siege! Our men were ranged in lines of seventeen deep
Before the gates, and never left their posts there, even to sleep.
Shall I not smite the rash presumption then of foes like these,
Detested both of all the gods and of Euripides--[4]
Else, may the Marathon-plain not boast my trophied victories! [5]

Ah, now, there's but a little space
To reach the place!
A deadly climb it is, a tricky road
With all this bumping load:
A pack-ass soon would tire.... [6]
How these logs bruise my shoulders! further still
Jog up the hill,
And puff the fire inside,
Or just as we reach the top we'll find it's died.
Ough, phew!
I choke with the smoke.

Lord Heracles, [7] how acrid-hot
Out of the pot
This mad-dog smoke leaps, worrying me
And biting angrily....
'Tis Lemnian fire [8] that smokes,
Or else it would not sting my eyelids thus....

Haste, all of us;
Athena invokes our aid.
Laches, now or never the assault must be made!
Ough, phew!
I choke with the smoke. ..

Thanked be the gods! The fire peeps up and crackles as it should.
Now why not first slide off our backs these weary loads of wood
And dip a vine-branch in the brazier till it glows, then straight
Hurl it at the battering-ram against the stubborn gate? [9]
If they refuse to draw the bolts in immediate compliance,
We'll set fire to the wood, and smoke will strangle their defiance.

Phew, what a spluttering drench of smoke! Come, now from off my back....
Is there no Samos-general [10] to help me to unpack?
Ah there, that's over! For the last time now it's galled my shoulder.
Flare up your embers, brazier, and dutifully smolder,
To kindle a brand, that I the first may strike the citadel.
Aid me, Lady Victory, [11] that a triumph-trophy [12] may tell
How we did anciently this insane audacity quell!

Chorus of WOMEN. [13]

What's that rising yonder? That ruddy glare, that smoky skurry?
O is it something in a blaze? Quick, quick, my comrades, hurry!
Nicodice, helter-skelter!
Or poor Calyce's in flames
And Cratylla's stifled in the welter.
O these dreadful old men
And their dark laws of hate!
There, I'm all of a tremble lest I turn out to be too late.
I could scarcely get near to the spring though I rose before dawn,
What with tattling of tongues and rattling of pitchers in one jostling din
With slaves pushing in!.... [14]

Still here at last the water's drawn
And with it eagerly I run
To help those of my friends who stand
In danger of being burned alive.
For I am told a dribbling band
Of greybeards hobble to the field,
Great brush-bundles in each palsied hand,
As if a hot bath to prepare,
And threatening that out they'll drive
These wicked women or soon leave them charring into ashes there.
O Goddess, suffer not, I pray, this harsh deed to be done,
But show us Greece and Athens with their warlike acts repealed!
For this alone, in this your hold,
O Goddess with the helm of gold,
We laid hands on your sanctuary, [15]
Athena.... Then our ally be
And where they cast their fires of slaughter
Direct our water!

STRATYLLIS (caught)

Let me go!

WOMEN

You villainous old men, what's this you do?
No honest man, no pious man, could do such things as you.

MEN

Ah ha, here's something most original, I have no doubt:
A swarm of women sentinels to man the walls without.

WOMEN

So then we scare you, do we? Do we seem a fearful host?
You only see the smallest fraction mustered at this post.

MEN

Ho, Phaedrias, shall we put a stop to all these chattering tricks?
Suppose that now upon their backs we splintered these our sticks?

WOMEN

Let us lay down the pitchers, so our bodies will be free,
In case these lumping fellows try to cause some injury.

MEN

O hit them hard and hit again and hit until they run away,
And perhaps they'll learn, like Bupalus, [16] not to have too much to say.

WOMEN

Come on, then--do it! I won't budge, but like a dog I'll bite
At every little scrap of meat that dangles in my sight.

MEN

Be quiet, or I'll bash you out of any years to come.

WOMEN

Now you just touch Stratyllis with the top-joint of your thumb.

MEN

What vengeance can you take if with my fists your face I beat?

WOMEN

I'll rip you with my teeth and strew your entrails at your feet.

MEN

Now I appreciate Euripides' strange subtlety: [17]
Woman is the most shameless beast of all the beasts that be.

WOMEN

Rhodippe, come, and let's pick up our water-jars once more.

MEN

Ah cursed drab, what have you brought this water for?

WOMEN

What is your fire for then, you smelly corpse? Yourself to burn?

MEN

To build a pyre and make your comrades ready for the urn. [18]

WOMEN

And I've the water to put out your fire immediately.

MEN

What, you put out my fire?

WOMEN

Yes, sirrah, as you soon will see.

MEN

I don't know why I hesitate to roast you with this flame.

WOMEN

If you have any soap you'll go off cleaner than you came.

MEN

Cleaner, you dirty slut?

WOMEN

A nuptial-bath in which to lie! [\[19\]](#)

MEN

Did you hear that insolence?

WOMEN

I'm a free woman, I. [\[20\]](#)

MEN

I'll make you hold your tongue.

WOMEN

Henceforth you'll serve in no more juries. [\[21\]](#)

MEN

Burn off her hair for her.

WOMEN

Now forward, water, quench their furies!

MEN

O dear, O dear!

WOMEN

So ... was it hot?

MEN

Hot! ... Enough, O hold.

WOMEN

Watered, perhaps you'll bloom again--why not?

MEN

Brrr, I'm wrinkled up from shivering with cold.

WOMEN

Next time you've fire you'll warm yourself and leave us to our lot.

MAGISTRATE [22] (enters with attendant SCYTHIANS) [23].

MAGISTRATE

Have the luxurious rites of the women glittered
Their libertine show, their drumming tapped out crowds,
The Sabazian Mysteries summoned their mob, [24]
Adonis [25] been wept to death on the terraces,
As I could hear the last day in the Assembly? [26]
For Demostratus [27]--let bad luck befoul him--
Was roaring, "We must sail for Sicily," [28]
While a woman, throwing herself about in a dance
Lopsided with drink, was shrilling out "Adonis,
Woe for Adonis." Then Demostratus shouted,
"We must levy hoplites [29] at Zacynthus,"
And there the woman, up to the ears in wine,
Was screaming "Weep for Adonis" on the house-top,
The scoundrelly politician, that lunatic ox,
Bellowing bad advice through tipsy shrieks:
Such are the follies wantoning in them.

MEN

O if you knew their full effrontery!
All of the insults they've done, besides sousing us
With water from their pots to our public disgrace
For we stand here wringing our clothes like grown-up infants.

MAGISTRATE

By Poseidon, justly done! For in part with us
The blame must lie for dissolute behavior
And for the pampered appetites they learn.
Thus grows the seedling lust to blossoming:
We go into a shop and say, "Here, goldsmith,
You remember the necklace that you wrought my wife;
Well, the other night in fervor of a dance
Her clasp broke open. Now I'm off for Salamis;
If you've the leisure, would you go tonight
And stick a bolt-pin into her opened clasp."
Another goes to a cobbler; a soldierly fellow,
Always standing up erect, and says to him,
"Cobbler, a sandal-strap of my wife's pinches her,
Hurts her little toe in a place where she's sensitive.
Come at noon and see if you can stretch out wider
This thing that troubles her, loosen its tightness."
And so you view the result. Observe my case--
I, a magistrate, come here to draw
Money to buy oar-blades, and what happens?
The women slam the door full in my face.
But standing still's no use. Bring me a crowbar,
And I'll chastise this their impertinence.
What do you gape at, wretch, with dazzled eyes?
Peering for a tavern, I suppose.
Come, force the gates with crowbars, pry them apart!
I'll pry away myself too.... (LYSISTRATA appears.)

LYSISTRATA

Stop this banging.
I'm coming of my own accord.... Why bars?
It is not bars we need but common sense.

MAGISTRATE

Indeed, you slut! Where is the archer now? [\[30\]](#)
Arrest this woman, tie her hands behind.

LYSISTRATA

If he brushes me with a finger, by Artemis, [\[31\]](#)
The public menial, [\[32\]](#) he'll be sorry for it.

MAGISTRATE

Are you afraid? Grab her about the middle.
Two of you then, lay hands on her and end it.

CALONICE

By Pandrosos, [\[33\]](#) if your hand touches her
I'll spread you out and trample on your guts.

MAGISTRATE

My guts! Where is the other archer gone?
Bind that minx there who talks so prettily.

MYRRHINE

By Phosphor, [\[34\]](#) if your hand moves out her way
You'd better have a surgeon somewhere handy.

MAGISTRATE

You too! Where is that archer? Take that woman.
I'll put a stop to these surprise-parties.

STRATYLLIS

By the Tauric Artemis, [\[35\]](#) one inch nearer
My fingers, and it's a bald man that'll be yelling.

MAGISTRATE

Tut tut, what's here? Deserted by my archers....
But surely women never can defeat us;
Close up your ranks, my Scythians. Forward at them.

LYSISTRATA

By the goddesses, you'll find that here await you
Four companies of most pugnacious women
Armed cap-a-pie from the topmost louting curl
To the lowest angry dimple.

MAGISTRATE

On, Scythians, bind them.

LYSISTRATA

On, gallant allies of our high design,
Vendors of grain-eggs-pulse-and-vegetables,
Ye garlic-tavern-keepers of bakeries,

Strike, batter, knock, hit, slap, and scratch our foes,
Be finely imprudent, say what you think of them....
Enough! Retire and do not rob the dead. [36]

MAGISTRATE

How basely did my archer-force come off.

LYSISTRATA

Ah, ha, you thought it was a herd of slaves [37]

You had to tackle, and you didn't guess
The thirst for glory ardent in our blood.

MAGISTRATE

By Apollo, I know well the thirst that heats you--
Especially when a wine-skin's close.

MEN

You waste your breath, dear magistrate, I fear, in answering back.
What's the good of argument with such a rampageous pack?
Remember how they washed us down (these very clothes I wore)
With water that looked nasty and that smelt so even more.

WOMEN

What else to do, since you advanced too dangerously nigh.
If you should do the same again, I'll punch you in the eye.
Though I'm a stay-at-home and most a quiet life enjoy,
Polite to all and every (for I'm naturally coy),
Still if you wake a wasps' nest then of wasps you must beware.

MEN

How may this ferocity be tamed? It grows too great to bear.
Let us question them and find if they'll perchance declare
The reason why they strangely dare
To seize on Cranaos' citadel,
This eyrie inaccessible,
This shrine above the precipice,
The Acropolis.
Probe them and find what they mean with this idle talk; listen,
but watch they don't try to deceive.
You'd be neglecting your duty most certainly if now this mystery
unplumbed you leave.

MAGISTRATE

Women there! Tell what I ask you, directly....
Come, without rambling, I wish you to state
What's your rebellious intention in barring up thus on our noses
our own temple-gate.

LYSISTRATA

To take first the treasury [38] out of your management, and so stop the war
through the absence of gold.

MAGISTRATE

Is gold then the cause of the war?

LYSISTRATA

Yes, gold caused it and miseries more, too many to be told.

It was for money, and money alone, that Pisander [39] with all of the army of mob-agitators

Raised up revolutions. But, as for the future, it won't be worth while to set up to be traitors.

Not an obol they'll get as their loot, not an obol! While we have the treasure-chest in our command.

MAGISTRATE

What then is that you propose?

LYSISTRATA

Just this--merely to take the exchequer henceforth in hand. [40]

MAGISTRATE

The exchequer!

LYSISTRATA

Yes, why not? Of our capabilities you have had various clear evidences.

Firstly remember we have always administered soundly the budget of all home-expenses.

MAGISTRATE

But this matter's different.

LYSISTRATA

How is it different?

MAGISTRATE

Why, it deals chiefly with war-time supplies.

LYSISTRATA

But we abolish war straight by our policy.

MAGISTRATE

What will you do if emergencies arise?

LYSISTRATA

Face them our own way.

MAGISTRATE

What *you* will?

LYSISTRATA

Yes *we* will!

MAGISTRATE

Then there's no help for it; we're all destroyed.

LYSISTRATA

No, willy-nilly you must be safeguarded.

MAGISTRATE

What madness is this?

LYSISTRATA

Why, it seems you're annoyed.

It must be done, that's all.

MAGISTRATE

Such awful oppression never,
O never in the past yet I bore.

LYSISTRATA

You must be saved, sirrah--that's all there is to it.

MAGISTRATE

If we don't want to be saved?

LYSISTRATA

All the more.

MAGISTRATE

Why do you women come prying and meddling in matters of state touching
war-time and peace?

LYSISTRATA

That I will tell you.

MAGISTRATE

O tell me or quickly I'll--

LYSISTRATA

Hearken awhile and from threatening cease.

MAGISTRATE

I cannot, I cannot; it's growing too insolent.

WOMEN

Come on; you've far more than we have to dread.

MAGISTRATE

Stop from your croaking, old carrion-crow there....
Continue.

LYSISTRATA

Be calm then and I'll go ahead.

All the long years when the hopeless war dragged along we, unassuming, forgotten in quiet,
Endured without question, endured in our loneliness all your incessant child's antics and riot.
Our lips we kept tied, though aching with silence, though well all the while in our silence we knew
How wretchedly everything still was progressing by listening dumbly the day long to you.
For always at home you continued discussing the war and its politics loudly, and we
Sometimes would ask you, our hearts deep with sorrowing though we spoke lightly, though happy to see,
"What's to be inscribed on the side of the Treaty-stone, [41] What, dear, was said in the Assembly today?"
"Mind your own business," he'd answer me growlingly, "hold your tongue, woman, or else go away."
And so I would hold it.

WOMEN

I'd not be silent for any man living on earth, no, not I!

MAGISTRATE

Not for a staff?

LYSISTRATA

Well, so I did nothing but sit in the house, feeling dreary, and sigh,
While ever arrived some fresh tale of decisions more foolish by far and presaging disaster.

Then I would say to him, "O my dear husband, why still do they rush on destruction the faster?"
At which he would look at me sideways, exclaiming, "Keep for your web and your shuttle your care,
Or for some hours hence your cheeks will be sore and hot; leave this alone, war is Man's sole affair!"

MAGISTRATE

By Zeus, but a man of fine sense, he.

LYSISTRATA

How sensible?

You dotard, because he at no time had lent

His intractable ears to absorb from our counsel one temperate word of advice, kindly meant?

But when at the last in the streets we heard shouted (everywhere ringing the ominous cry)

"Is there no one to help us, no savior in Athens?" and, "No, there is no one," come back in reply.

At once a convention of all wives through Hellas [42] here for a serious purpose was held,

To determine how husbands might yet back to wisdom despite their reluctance in time be compelled.

Why then delay any longer? It's settled. For the future you'll take up our old occupation.

Now in turn you're to hold tongue, as we did, and listen while we show the way to recover the nation.

MAGISTRATE

You talk to *us*! Why, you're mad. I'll not stand it.

LYSISTRATA

Cease babbling, you fool; till I end, hold your tongue.

MAGISTRATE

If I should take orders from one who wears veils, may my
neck straightaway be deservedly wrung.

LYSISTRATA

O if that keeps pestering you,

I've a veil here for your hair,

I'll fit you out in everything

As is only fair.

CALONICE

Here's a spindle that will do.

MYRRHINE

I'll add a wool-basket too.

LYSISTRATA

Girdled now sit humbly at home,

Munching beans, [43] while you card wool and comb. For war from now on
is the Women's affair.

WOMEN.

Come then, down pitchers, all,

And on, courageous of heart,

In our comradely venture

Each taking her due part.

I could dance, dance, dance, and be fresher after,

I could dance away numberless suns,

To no weariness let my knees bend.

Earth I could brave with laughter,

Having such wonderful girls here to friend.
O the daring, the gracious, the beautiful ones!
Their courage unswerving and witty
Will rescue our city.

O sprung from the seed of most valiant-wombed grand-mothers,
scions of savage and dangerous nettles!
Prepare for the battle, all. Gird up your angers. Our way
the wind of sweet victory settles.

LYSISTRATA

O tender Eros [44] and Lady of Cyprus, [45] some flush of beauty I pray you devise
To flash on our bosoms and, O Aphrodite, rosily gleam on our valorous thighs!
Joy will raise up its head through the legions warring and all of the far-serried ranks of mad-love
Bristle the earth to the pillared horizon, pointing in vain to the heavens above.
I think that perhaps then they'll give us our title--Peace-makers.

MAGISTRATE

What do you mean? Please explain.

LYSISTRATA

First, we'll not see you now flourishing arms about into the market-place clang again.

WOMEN

No, by the Paphian.

LYSISTRATA

Still I can conjure them as past were the herbs stand or crockery's sold
Like Corybants [46] jingling (poor sots) fully armored, they noisily round on their promenade strolled.

MAGISTRATE

And rightly; that's discipline, they--

LYSISTRATA

But what's sillier than to go on an errand of buying a fish
Carrying along an immense. Gorgon-buckler [47] instead the usual platter or dish?
A phylarch [48] I lately saw, mounted on horse-back, dressed for the part with long ringlets and all,
Stow in his helmet the omelet bought steaming from an old woman who kept a food-stall.
Nearby a soldier, a Thracian, [49] was shaking wildly his spear like Tereus [50] in the play,
To frighten a fig-girl while unseen the ruffian filched from her fruit-trays the ripest away.

MAGISTRATE

How, may I ask, will your rule re-establish order and justice in lands so tormented?

LYSISTRATA

Nothing is easier.

MAGISTRATE

Out with it speedily--what is this plan that you boast you've invented?

LYSISTRATA

If, when yarn we are winding, It chances to tangle, then, as perchance you may know, through the skein
This way and that still the spool we keep passing till it is finally clear all again:
So to untangle the War and its errors, ambassadors out on all sides we will send
This way and that, here, there and round about--soon you will find that the War has an end.

MAGISTRATE

So with these trivial tricks of the household, domestic analogies of threads, skeins and spools,
You think that you'll solve such a bitter complexity, unwind such political problems, you fools!

LYSISTRATA

Well, first as we wash dirty wool so's to cleanse it, so with a pitiless zeal we will scrub
Through the whole city for all greasy fellows; burrs too, the parasites, off we will rub.
That verminous plague of insensate place-seekers [51] soon between thumb and forefinger we'll crack.
All who inside Athens' walls have their dwelling into one great common basket we'll pack.
Disenfranchised or citizens, allies or aliens, [52] pell-mell the lot of them in we will squeeze.
Till they discover humanity's meaning.... As for disjointed and far colonies, [53]
Them you must never from this time imagine as scattered about just like lost hanks of wool.
Each portion we'll take and wind in to this center, inward to Athens each loyalty pull,
Till from the vast heap where all's piled together at last can be woven a strong cloak of State.

MAGISTRATE

How terrible is it to stand here and watch them carding and winding at will with our fate, [54]
Witless in war as they are.

LYSISTRATA

What of us then, who ever in vain for our children must weep
Borne but to perish afar and in vain?

MAGISTRATE

Not that, O let that one memory sleep!

LYSISTRATA

Then while we should be companioned still merrily, happy as brides may, the livelong night,
Kissing youth by, we are forced to lie single.... But leave for a moment our pitiful plight,
It hurts even more to behold the poor maidens helpless wrinkling in staler virginity.

MAGISTRATE

Does not a man age?

LYSISTRATA

Not in the same way. Not as a woman grows withered, grows he.
He, when returned from the war, though grey-headed, yet
if he wishes can choose out a wife.
But she has no solace save peering for omens, wretched and
lonely the rest of her life.

MAGISTRATE

But the old man will often select--

LYSISTRATA

O why not finish and die? [55]
A bier is easy to buy,
A honey-cake I'll knead you with joy,
This garland will see you are decked.

CALONICE

I've a wreath for you too.

MYRRHINE

I also will fillet you. [56]

LYSISTRATA

What more is lacking? Step aboard the boat. [57]
See, Charon shouts ahoy.
You're keeping him, he wants to shove afloat.

MAGISTRATE

Outrageous insults! Thus my place to flout!
Now to my fellow-magistrates I'll go
And what you've perpetrated on me show.

LYSISTRATA

Why are you blaming us for laying you out?
Assure yourself we'll not forget to make
The third day offering early for your sake. [58]

(MAGISTRATE retires and LYSISTRATA returns within).

Footnotes:

- [1] Lycon was an Athenian citizen who held prominent offices and whose wife had a reputation for sexual promiscuity.
- [2] Demeter (Latin: Ceres) was goddess of the harvest (meant to be ironic as she ensured the production of the bread the old men accuse their wives of consuming).
- [3] The old men pretend to remember participating in a campaign which occurred well before their time, when a Spartan king and general had briefly occupied the Acropolis in 508 BCE.
- [4] Euripides' plays frequently featured portraits of women which could be read as misogynistic fears brought to life on stage.
- [5] The famous battle of Marathon (480 BCE) occurred during the Persian Wars, so these men would have to be nearly 100 years old.
- [6] Pack-asses or donkeys were traditionally used to carry heavy loads, and still are today.
- [7] Heracles (Latin: Hercules) was a famed Greek hero venerated as a demi-god by some. They are comparing their labors to his.
- [8] According to legend, the goddess Aphrodite (Venus) punished the women of Lemnos, who had neglected her worship, by making them physically stink. Infidelity and abandonment resulted, and the Lemnian women punished their unfaithful husbands with death.
- [9] Lysistrata and her allies had blocked the Propylaea, the ceremonial gates which controlled access to the Acropolis. See this map: <http://arthistoryresources.net/greek-art-archaeology-2016/acropolis.html> and 3D video: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8smmU8MseWE>
- [10] Samos was the base for the Athenian navy.
- [11] There was a temple dedicated to Athena Nike (Athena as Victory) just inside the Propylaeian gates. Both Athena and Nike (sometimes personified as a separate goddess) were depicted as female. See note 9 above.
- [12] A pole or tree displaying the enemy's captured armor and weapons. See a Roman version here: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tropaion#/media/File:Booty_from_the_Dacian_wars.JPG
- [13] This chorus is separate from Lysistrata and her allies and is the counterpart to that of the old men.
- [14] For women drawing water from the communal water source, see: <https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/247244>
- [15] There were multiple temples dedicated in some shape or form to Athena, who was Athens' patron goddess. The speaker here probably refers to the Parthenon, with its famed massive statue of Athena with her trademark crested helmet, spear, and shield. See: <https://sketchfab.com/3d-models/the-parthenon-rebuilt-4552d90409924583b1fadfc9953134cb> and the reconstruction in Nashville, TN:
- [16] Bupalus was a sculptor who famously sparred with the poet Hipponax and later committed suicide because of the verbally abusive verses Hipponax circulated about him. Like that conflict, this fight will be mostly conducted with words.
- [17] Euripides was a famous writer of tragic plays featuring female characters who challenged Greek gender norms.

- [18] In Athens, most deceased citizens were cremated in elaborate ceremonies and their bones and ashes placed in urns afterwards. See: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Urn#/media/File:Geometric_Cremation_urn_Athens_Agora_Museum.jpg
- [19] It was customary for both brides and grooms to take a ritual bath as part of the marriage festivities.
- [20] Or, as Sarah Ruden translates it: "I'm not a slave" (Ruden 23).
- [21] Citizens could exercise considerable power and earn a daily salary by serving on juries and some older men appear to have done so somewhat obsessively. Aristophanes mocks this in his play, *Wasps*.
- [22] Shortly before Aristophanes wrote *Lysistrata*, the Council of Five Hundred ceded many of its administrative powers to a board of ten councilors or magistrates.
- [23] Scythian slaves formed the government-owned security force and acted as bodyguards for public officials. Scythians were considered "barbarians" by the Greeks.
- [24] Sabazios was originally a god worshipped by the Phrygians and Thracians. When the Greeks adopted his worship, they assigned to him attributes of both Zeus and Dionysus. He appears to have been worshipped with rites similar to those of other mystery cults. Some Athenian men suspected that women were using such rites to escape male control.
- [25] Traditionally women ritually lamented the death of Adonis from the flat rooftops of their houses. Aphrodite had taken him as a lover before his tragic death, commemorated in annual festival.
- [26] By this he means the General Assembly, attended in theory by every male citizen.
- [27] Demostratus was an Athenian citizen who put forward a proposal for the ill-fated Sicilian expedition, which resulted in a resounding defeat for Athens. The woman lamenting Adonis' death foreshadows the young men lost there.
- [28] Southern Italy and Sicily were known in the Roman empire as "Magna Grecia" due to the large amounts of Greek peoples that settled there.
- [29] Armed Greek citizen foot-soldiers who fought in phalanx formation with shield and spear. See: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hoplite#/media/File:Hoplite_5th_century.jpg
- [30] He's referring to the Scythians. In Athens, the "Scythian Archers," served some of the functions we currently associate with police forces. They practice crowd control during public gatherings (the Council, the Assembly, and the Agora) and appear to have been authorized to use non-lethal force against citizens in certain scenarios. The "Scythian Archers" were slaves owned by the state who worked as guards and watchmen. There are real tensions between citizens and police forces in the United States, and there were in Athens as well.
- [31] Artemis was goddess of the hunt and a famed archer herself.
- [32] Lysistrata refers to the Scythian's unfree status.
- [33] Pandrosos was a legendary Athenian princess.
- [34] An epithet, "Light-Bearer" associated with both Hecate, goddess of magic and Artemis, goddess of the hunt.
- [35] One of Artemis' titles was "Drawn by a Bull," presumably referring to an ox-drawn cart.
- [36] Lysistrata barks orders like a commander. *The Iliad* is full of scenes of champion warriors despoiling their slain opponent of their weapons and armor as trophies or loot. Presumably Aristophanes' audience found this parody of epic knee-slappingly funny.
- [37] A comparison worth dwelling on.
- [38] The Athenian public treasury was located in the Acropolis.
- [39] In 411 BCE, Pisander would stage a coup. He was an Athenian aristocrat who believed in rule by the few (oligarchy).
- [40] The equivalent of taking over the Federal Reserve, The Department of the Treasury, and Fort Knox's gold supply. And assuming the budget-determining capabilities of Congress.
- [41] Treaties were often literally engraved in stone and in 418 BCE the Athenian Assembly decided to alter a treaty agreed on with Sparta by publicly inscribing an addition saying that the Spartans had broken its conditions.
- [42] We might say "Greece." The Hellenes was a term used to refer to Greek-speaking city-states.

- [43] We chew gum, the Greeks chewed beans. Carding (cleaning and detangling) wool and textile preparation were considered women's work.
- [44] God of sexual love.
- [45] Venus/Aphrodite, goddess of sexual love.
- [46] Male devotees of the Phrygian goddess Cybele who honored her by dancing in full battle-gear.
- [47] There were three female gorgons with heads of snake-hair, whose gaze turned humans to stone. Their image was often put on shield-bosses and armor to intimidate enemies.
- [48] A phylarch was the elected commander of a cavalry unit provided by each of the city's ten tribes. Imagine someone driving into a crowded farmer's market.
- [49] Thracians were often employed by Athens as mercenaries but were viewed as very nearly barbarian.
- [50] A famously savage mythical Thracian king.
- [51] She compares these people to lice who need to be squashed.
- [52] This is an important panorama of the different groups living in Athens, including metics or foreigners, who could not vote.
- [53] Athens was at this point in time aggressively colonizing large areas of the Mediterranean.
- [54] The fates were often depicted as three women who determined an individual's life outcome. Their control was described in metaphors of spinning and weaving.
- [55] The lines that follow mimic Greek funeral rites, in which women played a dominant role.
- [56] Put a garland on his head.
- [57] When bodies were laid out for a viewing, they were given a cake to bribe Cerberus, three-headed guardian dog of the underworld, and coins to pay Charon, who ferried the souls of the dead over the river Styx.
- [58] Probably referring to the offerings made when the body of the deceased was ritually interred after cremation.
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2.3: Section 3

(MAGISTRATE retires, LYSISTRATA returns within).

OLD MEN.

All men who call your loins your own, awake at last, arise
And strip to stand in readiness. For as it seems to me
Some more perilous offensive in their heads they now devise.

I'm sure a tyranny

Like that of Hippias [1]

In this I detect....

They mean to put us under

Themselves I suspect,

And that Laconians [2] assembling

At Cleisthenes' [3] house have played

A trick-of-war and provoked them

Madly to raid

The Treasury, in which term I include

The pay for my food. [4]

For is it not preposterous

They should talk this way to us

On a subject such as battle!

And, women as they are, about bronze bucklers dare prattle--

Make alliance with the Spartans--people I for one

Like very hungry wolves would always most sincere shun....

Some dirty game is up their sleeve,

I believe.

A Tyranny, no doubt... but they won't catch me, that know.

Henceforth on my guard I'll go,

A sword with myrtle-branches wreathed for ever in my hand,

And under arms in the public place I'll take my watchful stand,

Shoulder to shoulder with Aristogeiton. [5] Now my staff I'll draw

And start at once by knocking

that shocking

Hag upon the jaw.

WOMEN.

Your own mother will not know you when you get back to the town.

But first, my friends and allies, let us lay these garments down,

And all ye fellow-citizens, hark to me while I tell

What will aid Athens well.

Just as is right, for I

Have been a sharer

In all the lavish splendor

Of the proud city. [6]

I bore the holy vessels

At seven, then

I pounded barley

At the age of ten,

And clad in yellow robes,

Soon after this,

I was Little Bear to

Brauronian Artemis;
Then necklaced with figs,
Grown tall and pretty,
I was a Basket-bearer,
And so it's obvious I should
Give you advice that I think good,
The very best I can.
It should not prejudice my voice that I'm not born a man,
If I say something advantageous to the present situation.
For I'm taxed too, and as a toll provide men for the nation [7]
While, miserable greybeards, you,
It is true,
Contribute nothing of any importance whatever to our needs;
But the treasure raised against the Medes
You've squandered, [8] and do nothing in return, save that you make
Our lives and persons hazardous by some imbecile mistakes
What can you answer? Now be careful, don't arouse my spite,
Or with my slipper I'll take you napping,
faces slapping
Left and right.

MEN.

What villainies they contrive!
Come, let vengeance fall,
You that below the waist are still alive,
Off with your tunics at my call--
Naked, all.
For a man must strip to battle like a man.
No quaking, brave steps taking, careless what's ahead, white shoed,
in the nude, onward bold,
All ye who garrisoned Leipsidrion [9] of old....
Let each one wag
As youthfully as he can,
And if he has the cause at heart
Rise at least a span.

We must take a stand and keep to it,
For if we yield the smallest bit
To their importunity.
Then nowhere from their inroads will be left to us immunity.
But they'll be building ships and soon their navies will attack us,
As Artemisia did [10], and seek to fight us and to sack us.
And if they mount, the knights they'll rob
Of a job,
For everyone knows how talented they all are in the saddle,
Having long practiced how to straddle;
No matter how they're jogged there up and down, they're never thrown.
Then think of Myron's painting, [11] and each horse-backed Amazon [12]
In combat hand-to-hand with men.... Come, on these women fall,
And in pierced wood-collars let's stick
quick
The necks of one and all.

WOMEN.

Don't cross me or I'll loose
The beast that's kenneled here....
And soon you will be howling for a truce,
Howling out with fear.
But my dear,
Strip also, that women may battle unhindered....
But you, you'll be too sore to eat garlic more, or one black bean, [13]
I really mean, so great's my spleen, to kick you black and blue
With these my dangerous legs.
I'll hatch the lot of you,
If my rage you dash on,
The way the relentless beetle
Hatched the eagle's eggs. [14]

Scornfully aside I set
Every silly old-man threat
While Lampito's with me.
Or dear Ismenia, the noble Theban girl. Then let decree
Be hotly piled upon decree; in vain will be your labors,
You futile rogue abominated by your suffering neighbor
To Hecate's [15] feast I yesterday went--
Off I sent
To our neighbors in Boeotia, asking as a gift to me
For them to pack immediately
That darling dainty thing ... a good fat eel [16] I meant of course;
But they refused because some idiotic old decree's in force.
O this strange passion for decrees nothing on earth can check,
Till someone puts a foot out tripping you, and slipping you
Break your neck.

(LYSISTRATA enters in dismay).

WOMEN

Dear Mistress of our martial enterprise,
Why do you come with sorrow in your eyes?

LYSISTRATA

O 'tis our naughty femininity,
So weak in one spot, that hath saddened me.

WOMEN

What's this? Please speak.

LYSISTRATA

Poor women, O so weak!

WOMEN

What can it be? Surely your friends may know.

LYSISTRATA

Yea, I must speak it though it hurt me so.

WOMEN

Speak; can we help? Don't stand there mute in need.

LYSISTRATA

I'll blurt it out then--our women's army's mutinied.

WOMEN

O Zeus!

LYSISTRATA

What use is Zeus to our anatomy?
Here is the gaping calamity I meant:
I cannot shut their ravenous appetites
A moment more now. They are all deserting.
The first I caught was sidling through the postern
Close by the Cave of Pan: [17] the next hoisting herself
With rope and pulley down: a third on the point
Of slipping past: while a fourth malcontent, seated
For instant flight to visit Orsilochus [18]
On bird-back, I dragged off by the hair in time....
They are all snatching excuses to sneak home.
Look, there goes one.... Hey, what's the hurry?

1ST WOMAN

I must get home. I've some Milesian wool
Packed wasting away, and moths are pushing through it.

LYSISTRATA

Fine moths indeed, I know. Get back within.

1ST WOMAN

By the goddesses, [19] I'll return instantly.
I only want to stretch it on my bed.

LYSISTRATA

You shall stretch nothing and go nowhere either.

1ST WOMAN

Must I never use my wool then?

LYSISTRATA

If needs be.

2ND WOMAN

How unfortunate I am! O my poor flax!
It's left at home unstripped.

LYSISTRATA

So here's another
That wishes to go home and strip her flax.
Inside again!

2ND WOMAN

No, by the goddess of Light, [20]
I'll be back as soon as I have flayed it properly.

LYSISTRATA

You'll not flay anything. For if you begin
There'll not be one here but has a patch to be flayed.

3RD WOMAN

O holy Eilithya, stay this birth [21]
Till I have left the precincts of the place!

LYSISTRATA

What nonsense is this?

3RD WOMAN

I'll drop it any minute.

LYSISTRATA

Yesterday you weren't with child.

3RD WOMAN

But I am today.
O let me find a midwife, Lysistrata.
O quickly!

LYSISTRATA

Now what story is this you tell?
What is this hard lump here?

3RD WOMAN

It's a male child.

LYSISTRATA

By Aphrodite, [22] it isn't. Your belly's hollow,
And it has the feel of metal.... Well, I soon can see.
You hussy, it's Athena's sacred helm, [23]
And you said you were with child.

3RD WOMAN

And so I am.

LYSISTRATA

Then why the helm?

3RD WOMAN

So if the throes should take me
Still in these grounds I could use it like a dove
As a laying-nest in which to drop the child.

LYSISTRATA

More pretexts! You can't hide your clear intent,
And anyway why not wait till the tenth day
Meditating a brazen name for your brass brat? [24]

WOMAN

And I can't sleep a wink. My nerve is gone
Since I saw that snake-sentinel of the shrine. [25]

WOMAN

And all those dreadful owls [26] with their weird hooting!
Though I'm wearied out, I can't close an eye.

LYSISTRATA

You wicked women, cease from juggling lies.
You want your men. But what of them as well?
They toss as sleepless in the lonely night,
I'm sure of it. Hold out awhile, hold out,
But persevere a teeny-weeny longer.
An oracle has promised victory
If we don't wrangle. Would you hear the words?

WOMEN

Yes, yes, what is it?

LYSISTRATA

Silence then, you chatterboxes.

Here--

"When as the swallows flocking in one place from the hoopoes
Deny themselves love's gambols any more,
All woes shall then have ending and great Zeus the Thunderer
Shall put above what was below before." [27]

WOMEN

Will the men then always be kept under us?

LYSISTRATA

"But if the swallows squabble among themselves and fly away
Out of the temple, refusing to agree,
Then The Most Wanton Birds in all the World
They shall be named for ever. That's his decree."

WOMAN

It's obvious what it means.

LYSISTRATA

Now by all the gods
We must let no agony deter from duty,
Back to your quarters. For we are base indeed,
My friends, if we betray the oracle.

(She goes out).

OLD MEN.

I'd like to remind you of a fable [28] they used to employ,
When I was a little boy:
How once through fear of the marriage-bed a young man,
Melanion by name, to the wilderness ran,
And there on the hills he dwelt.
For hares he wove a net
Which with his dog he set--
Most likely he's there yet.
For he never came back home, so great was the fear he felt.
I loathe the sex as much as he,
And therefore I no less shall be
As chaste as was Melanion.

MAN

Grann'am, do you much mind men?

WOMAN

Onions you won't need, to cry.

MAN

From my foot you shan't escape.

WOMAN

What thick forests I espy.

MEN

So much Myronides' fierce beard
And thundering black back were feared,
That the foe fled when they were shown--
Brave he as Phormion. [\[29\]](#)

WOMEN.

Well, I'll relate a rival fable just to show to you
A different point of view: [\[30\]](#)
There was a rough-hewn fellow, Timon, with a face
That glowered as through a thorn-bush in a wild, bleak place.
He too decided on flight,
This very Furies' son, [\[31\]](#)
All the world's ways to shun
And hide from everyone,
Spitting out curses on all knavish men to left and right.
But though he reared this hate for men,
He loved the women even then,
And never thought them enemies.

WOMAN

O your jaw I'd like to break.

MAN

That I fear do you suppose?

WOMAN

Learn what kicks my legs can make.

MAN

Raise them up, and you'll expose--

WOMAN

Nay, you'll see there, I engage,
All is well kept despite my age,
And tended smooth enough to slip
From any adversary's grip.

(LYSISTRATA appears).

LYSISTRATA

Hello there, hasten here to me,
Skip fast along.

WOMAN

What is this? Why the noise?

LYSISTRATA

A man, a man! I spy a frenzied man!
He carries Love upon him like a staff.
O Lady of Cyprus, and Cythera, and Paphos, [32]
I beseech you, keep our minds and hands to the oath.

WOMAN

Where is he, whoever he is?

LYSISTRATA

By the Temple of Chloe. [33]

WOMAN

Yes, now I see him, but who can he be?

LYSISTRATA

Look at him. Does anyone recognize his face?

MYRRHINE

I do. He is my husband, Cinesias. [34]

LYSISTRATA

You know how to work. Play with him, lead him on,
Seduce him to the cozening-point--kiss him, kiss him,
Then slip your mouth aside just as he's sure of it,
Ungirdle every caress his mouth feels at
Save that the oath upon the bowl has locked.

MYRRHINE

You can rely on me.

LYSISTRATA

I'll stay here to help
In working up his ardor to its height
Of vain magnificence.... The rest to their quarters.

Footnotes:

[1] A famous tyrant who ruled Athens until 510 BCE. On tyrants in Athens, see the introduction (1.1).

[2] Spartans.

[3] An Athenian delegate (*theoros*) who played a prominent role during the Peloponnesian War. Aristophanes targetted him mercilessly in multiple plays, playing on his reputation for homosexuality and/or effeminacy. Athenians considered Spartans proponents of anal sex. The implication is that Cleisthenes is literally "in bed" with the Spartans.

[4] The idea here is that the Old Men have a vested interest in keeping the war going. They are invested in keeping state benefits which help them funded, by war if necessary.

[5] Apparently this is a line from a popular drinking song about Harmodius and Aristogeiton plotting to assassinate Hippias (the tyrant mentioned above).

[6] In the rest of her speech, the speaker refers to one way in which women were permitted to participate in civic life--religious rituals. Young virgins bore ceremonials vessels and ground grain used in offerings of consecrated cakes, both for Athena. The "bears" served Artemis. The highest aspiration one could achieve was to carry the basket at the Panathenaea, an important annual festival dedicated to Athena. Figs symbolized fertility (because of their many seeds).

- [7] Athenian women bore the sons who served in Athenian armies.
- [8] Considerable war funds had been raised by Athens and her allies for the Persian Wars, some of which were diverted to build the Parthenon and fund public programs.
- [9] In an attempt to expel Hippias, this town had been occupied and militarized in the 6th century BCE. This would make those serving there impossibly old.
- [10] Herodotus tells the story of Queen Artemisia, who fought on the Persian side at the Battle of Salamis (480 BCE).
- [11] Ruden has "Micon" (39)
- [12] Mythical female mounted warriors depicted in various public artworks all over Athens, including marble friezes on the Parthenon and on the shield of Athena in the same temple.
- [13] Jurors chewed beans like we chew gum; soldiers were fond of garlic. By the time the women are through with them the men will be unable to perform jury duty or military service.
- [14] This well-known fable featured a beetle who took vengeance on a female eagle by tipping her eggs out of her nest. He then forced Zeus to drop another clutch of eagle's eggs by flying at him.
- [15] Goddess of magic.
- [16] Boeotian eels were a delicacy whose import was banned as part of a trade embargo.
- [17] The Cave of Pan was a shrine on the northern slope of the Acropolis' hill. See: [https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:The_cave_of_Pan_\(33641627775\).jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:The_cave_of_Pan_(33641627775).jpg)
- [18] He kept a notorious brothel in Athens.
- [19] Demeter and Kore.
- [20] Hecate.
- [21] Goddess of childbirth who could assist or stall delivery of a child. Birth and the attendant loss of blood was held to "pollute" holy places such as the Acropolis.
- [22] Goddess of love.
- [23] The statue of Athena in the Parthenon had a metal helmet. See the reconstruction in Nashville, TN: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Athena_at_Parthenon_in_Nashville,_TN,_US.jpg
- [24] Traditionally families named a child at the *amphidromia* ceremony.
- [25] 407 BCE saw the completion of the Erechtheum, or temple to Athena, Erechtheus (mythical king of Athens who had a snake-sentinel living in a cave on the Acropolis) and other gods. See: <https://www.ancient.eu/Erechtheion/>
- [26] A bird associated with Athena and Athens. See: http://www.teachinghistory100.org/objects/about_the_object/a_silver_coin_from_athens
- [27] These birds refer to the tragic story of Philomena and Tereus, treated by Ovid in his *Metamorphoses*. Aristophanes is joking about the use of oracles and the way they are subject to (mis)interpretation.
- [28] The old men perhaps deliberately misremember the story. Melanion used to go hunting in order to meet with the female hero Atalanta in most versions of the story.
- [29] Both Myronides and Phormion were war heroes in Athens.
- [30] The women, too, are playing fast and loose with the story. Timon supposedly shunned human company, not men in particular.
- [31] Monstrous goddesses of vengeance who pursued evil-doers.
- [32] Aphrodite, goddess of erotic love.
- [33] An area sacred to Demeter Chloe.
- [34] His name is derived from the Greek term for "f--k".

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2.4: Section 4

(Enter CINESIAS).

Who is this that stands within our lines?

CINESIAS

I.

LYSISTRATA

A man?

CINESIAS

Too much a man!

LYSISTRATA

Then be off at once.

CINESIAS

Who are you that thus eject me?

LYSISTRATA

Guard for the day.

CINESIAS

By all the gods, then call Myrrhine hither.

LYSISTRATA

So, call Myrrhine hither! Who are you?

CINESIAS

I am her husband Cinesias, son of Anthros. [\[1\]](#)

LYSISTRATA

Welcome, dear friend! That glorious name of yours

Is quite familiar in our ranks. Your wife

Continually has it in her mouth.

She cannot touch an apple or an egg

But she must say, "This to Cinesias!"

CINESIAS

O is that true?

LYSISTRATA

By Aphrodite, it is.

If the conversation strikes on men, your wife

Cuts in with, "All are boobies by Cinesias."

CINESIAS

Then call her here.

LYSISTRATA

And what am I to get?

CINESIAS

This, if you want it.... See, what I have here.
But not to take away.

LYSISTRATA

Then I'll call her.

CINESIAS

Be quick, be quick. All grace is wiped from life
Since she went away. O sad, sad am I
When there I enter on that loneliness,
And wine is unvintaged of the sun's flavor.
And food is tasteless. But I've put on weight.

MYRRHINE (above)

I love him O so much! but he won't have it.
Don't call me down to him.

CINESIAS

Sweet little Myrrhine!
What do you mean? Come here.

MYRRHINE

O no I won't.
Why are you calling me? You don't want me.

CINESIAS

Not want you! with this week-old strength of love.

MYRRHINE

Farewell.

CINESIAS

Don't go, please don't go, Myrrhine.
At least you'll hear our child. Call your mother, lad.

CHILD

Mummy ... mummy ... mummy!

CINESIAS

There now, don't you feel pity for the child?
He's not been fed or washed now for six days.

MYRRHINE

I certainly pity him with so heartless a father.

CINESIAS

Come down, my sweetest, come for the child's sake.

MYRRHINE

A trying life it is to be a mother!
I suppose I'd better go. (She comes down).

CINESIAS

How much younger she looks,
How fresher and how prettier! Myrrhine,
Lift up your lovely face, your disdainful face;

And your ankle ... let your scorn step out its worst;
It only rubs me to more ardor here.

MYRRHINE (playing with the child)

You're as innocent as he's iniquitous.
Let me kiss you, honey-petting, mother's darling.

CINESIAS

How wrong to follow other women's counsel
And let loose all these throbbing voids in yourself
As well as in me. Don't you go throb-throb?

MYRRHINE

Take away your hands.

CINESIAS

Everything in the house
Is being ruined.

MYRRHINE

I don't care at all.

CINESIAS

The roosters are picking all your web to rags.
Do you mind that?

MYRRHINE

Not I.

CINESIAS

What time we've wasted
We might have drenched with Paphian laughter, flung
On Aphrodite's Mysteries. O come here.

MYRRHINE

Not till a treaty finishes the war.

CINESIAS

If you must have it, then we'll get it done.

MYRRHINE

Do it and I'll come home. Till then I am bound.

CINESIAS

Well, can't your oath perhaps be got around?

MYRRHINE

No ... no ... still I'll not say that I don't love you.

CINESIAS

You love me! Then dear girl, let me also love you.

MYRRHINE

You must be joking. The boy's looking on.

CINESIAS

Here, Manes, [2] take the child home!... There, he's gone.
There's nothing in the way now. Come to the point.

MYRRHINE

Here in the open! In plain sight?

CINESIAS

In Pan's cave. [3]

A splendid place.

MYRRHINE

Where shall I dress my hair again
Before returning to the citadel?

CINESIAS

You can easily primp yourself in the Clepsydra. [4]

MYRRHINE

But how can I break my oath?

CINESIAS

Leave that to me,
I'll take all risk.

MYRRHINE

Well, I'll make you comfortable.

CINESIAS

Don't worry. I'd as soon lie on the grass.

MYRRHINE

No, by Apollo, in spite of all your faults
I won't have you lying on the nasty earth.
(From here MYRRHINE keeps on going off to fetch things.)

CINESIAS

Ah, how she loves me.

MYRRHINE

Rest there on the bench,
While I arrange my clothes. O what a nuisance,
I must find some cushions first.

CINESIAS

Why some cushions?
Please don't get them!

MYRRHINE

What? The plain, hard wood?
Never, by Artemis! That would be too vulgar.

CINESIAS

Open your arms!

MYRRHINE

No. Wait a second.

CINESIAS

O....

Then hurry back again.

MYRRHINE

Here the cushions are.

Lie down while I--O dear! But what a shame,

You need more pillows.

CINESIAS

I don't want them, dear.

MYRRHINE

But I do.

CINESIAS

Thwarted affection mine,

They treat you just like Heracles at a feast

With cheats of dainties, O disappointing arms! [5]

MYRRHINE

Raise up your head.

CINESIAS

There, that's everything at last.

MYRRHINE

Yes, all.

CINESIAS

Then run to my arms, you golden girl.

MYRRHINE

I'm loosening my girdle now. But you've not forgotten?

You're not deceiving me about the treaty?

CINESIAS

No, by my life, I'm not.

MYRRHINE

Why, you've no blanket.

CINESIAS

It's not the silly blanket's warmth but yours I want.

MYRRHINE

Never mind. You'll soon have both. I'll come straight back.

CINESIAS

The woman will choke me with her coverlets.

MYRRHINE

Get up a moment.

CINESIAS

I'm up high enough.

MYRRHINE

Would you like me to perfume you? [6]

CINESIAS

By Apollo, no!

MYRRHINE

By Aphrodite, I'll do it anyway.

CINESIAS

Lord Zeus, may she soon use up all the myrrh.

MYRRHINE

Stretch out your hand. Take it and rub it in.

CINESIAS

Hmm, it's not as fragrant as might be; that is,
Not before it's smeared. It doesn't smell of kisses.

MYRRHINE

How silly I am: I've brought you Rhodian scents.

CINESIAS

It's good enough, leave it, love.

MYRRHINE

You must be jesting.

CINESIAS

Plague rack the man who first compounded scent!

MYRRHINE

Here, take this flask.

CINESIAS

I've a far better one.
Don't tease me, come here, and get nothing more.

MYRRHINE

I'm coming.... I'm just drawing off my shoes....
You're sure you will vote for peace?

CINESIAS

I'll think about it.
(She runs off).
I'm dead: the woman's worn me all away.
She's gone and left me with an anguished pulse.

MEN

Balked in your amorous delight
How melancholy is your plight.
With sympathy your case I view;
For I am sure it's hard on you.
What human being could sustain
This unforeseen domestic strain,

And not a single trace
Of willing women in the place!

CINESIAS

O Zeus, what throbbing suffering!

MEN

She did it all, the harlot, she
With her atrocious harlotry.

WOMEN

Nay, rather call her darling-sweet.

MEN

What, sweet? She's a rude, wicked thing.

CINESIAS

A wicked thing, as I repeat.

O Zeus, O Zeus,

Can you not suddenly let loose

Some twirling hurricane to tear

Her flapping up along the air

And drop her, when she's whirled around,

Here to the ground

Neatly impaled upon the stake

That's ready upright for her sake.

(He goes out).

(Enter SPARTAN HERALD).

(The MAGISTRATE comes forward).

HERALD

What here gabs the Senate and the Prytanes? [7]

I've fetched despatches for them.

MAGISTRATE

Are you a man

Or a monstrosity? [8]

HERALD

My scrimp-brained lad,

I'm a herald, as you see, who have come from Sparta

About a peace.

MAGISTRATE

Then why do you hide that lance

That sticks out under your arms?

HERALD.

I've brought no lance.

MAGISTRATE

Then why do you turn aside and hold your cloak

So far out from your body? Is your groin swollen

With stress of traveling?

HERALD

By Castor, [\[9\]](#) I'll swear
The man is crazy.

MAGISTRATE

Indeed, your cloak is wide,
My rascal fellow.

HERALD

But I tell you no!
Enough joking!

MAGISTRATE

Well, what is it then?

HERALD

It's my despatch cane.

MAGISTRATE

Of course--a Spartan cane! [\[10\]](#)
But speak right out. I know all this too well.
Are new privations springing up in Sparta?

HERALD

Och, hard as could be: in lofty lusty columns
Our allies stand united. We must get Pellene. [\[11\]](#)

MAGISTRATE

Whence has this evil come? Is it from Pan? [\[12\]](#)

HERALD

No. Lampito first ran amock, then the others
Sprinted after her example, and blocked, the hussies,
Their wombs up tight against our every entreaty.

MAGISTRATE

What did you do?

HERALD

We are broken, and bent double,
Limp like men carrying lanterns in great winds
About the city. They won't let us even
With lightest finger skim their private pretties
Until we've concluded peace-terms with Hellas.

MAGISTRATE

So the conspiracy is universal;
This proves it. Then return to Sparta. Bid them
Send envoys with full powers to treat of peace;
And I will urge the Senate here to choose
Plenipotentiary ambassadors,
As argument adducing this connection.

HERALD

I'm off. Your wisdom none could contravert.
(They retire).

Footnotes:

- [1] Like saying: my name is "f--k", son of "man".
- [2] A slave attendant, probably.
- [3] A cave-shrine on the northern slope of the Acropolis hill.
- [4] A spring. Myrrhine has to ritually bathe to purify herself before she can re-enter the sacred precincts of the Acropolis.
- [5] Comedic plays often featured the deified hero Heracles/Hercules as a devious, unfaithful figure who is teased and duped.
- [6] Perfumes were oil-based in this period, and perfume flasks were phallus-shaped.
- [7] The herald is looking for the Spartan Council of Elders, then realizes he needs the Athenian equivalent, the Prytany Council (fifty men selected from the Council of Five Hundred who served for 1/10 of the calendar year).
- [8] Literally a "conisalus," a giant phallus representing a fertility spirit.
- [9] Castor and his twin brother Polydeuces were famous heroes and brothers of Helen of Sparta.
- [10] Spartan staffs were an encryption method used to send messages. They came in pairs--one was sent with the envoy, another stayed in Sparta. The message sent out was written on a strip of fabric wound around the home staff and would have been indecipherable unless wound around its matching staff.
- [11] Pellene was the name of a famous prostitute and a particular territory the Spartans wanted.
- [12] The god Pan was believed to inflict various disasters, hence our word "panic". Pan was also depicted as a satyr and satyrs were associated with lust.

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2.5: Section 5

MEN

There is no beast, no rush of fire, like woman so untamed.
She calmly goes her way where even panthers would be shamed.

WOMEN

And yet you are fool enough, it seems, to dare to war with me,
When for your faithful ally you might win me easily.

MEN

Never could the hate I feel for womankind grow less.

WOMEN

Then have your will. But I'll take pity on your nakedness.
For I can see just how ridiculous you look, and so
Will help you with your tunic if close up I now may go.

MEN

Well, that, by Zeus, is no scoundrel-deed, I frankly will admit.
I only took them off myself in a scoundrel raging-fit.

WOMEN

Now you look sensible, and that you're men no one could doubt.
If you were but good friends again, I'd take the insect out
That hurts your eye.

MEN

Is that what's wrong? That nasty bitie thing.
Please squeeze it out, and show me what it is that makes this sting.
It's been paining me a long while now.

WOMEN

Well I'll agree to that,
Although you're most unmannerly. O what a giant gnat.
Here, look! It comes from marshy Tricorysus, I can tell.

MEN

O thank you. It was digging out a veritable well.
Now that it's gone, I can't hold back my tears. See how they fall.

WOMEN

I'll wipe them off, bad as you are, and kiss you after all.

MEN

I won't be kissed.

WOMEN

O yes, you will. Your wishes do not matter.

MEN

O botheration take you all! How you cajole and flatter.
A hell it is to live with you; to live without, a hell:
How truly was that said. But come, these enmities let's quell.

You stop from giving orders and I'll stop from doing wrong.
So let's join ranks and seal our bargain with a choric song.

CHORUS.

Athenians, it's not our intention
To sow political dissension
By giving any scandal mention;
But on the contrary to promote good feeling in the state
By word and deed. We've had enough calamities of late.
So let a man or woman but divulge
They need a trifle, say,
Two minas, three or four, [1]
I've purses here that bulge.
There's only one condition made
(Indulge my whim in this I pray)--
When peace is signed once more,
On no account am I to be repaid. [2]

And I'm making preparation
For a gay select collation
With some youths of reputation. [3]
I've managed to produce some soup and they're slaughtering for me
A sucking-pig: its flesh should taste as tender as could be.
I shall expect you at my house today.
To the baths make an early visit,
And bring your children along;
Don't dawdle on the way.
Ask no one; enter as if the place
Was all your own--yours henceforth is it.
If nothing chances wrong,
The door will then be shut bang in your face.

The SPARTAN AMBASSADORS _approach_.

CHORUS

Here come the Spartan envoys with long, worried beards.
Hail, Spartans how do you fare?
Did anything new arise?

SPARTANS

No need for a clutter of words. Do you see our condition?

CHORUS

The situation swells to greater tension.
Something will explode soon.

SPARTANS

It's awful truly.
But come, let us with the best speed we may
Scribble a peace.

CHORUS

I notice that our men
Like wrestlers poised for contest, hold their clothes

Out from their bellies. An athlete's malady!
Since exercise alone can bring relief.

ATHENIANS

Can anyone tell us where Lysistrata is?
There is no need to describe our men's condition,
It shows up plainly enough.

CHORUS

It's the same disease.
Do you feel a jerking throbbing in the morning?

ATHENIANS

By Zeus, yes! In these straits, I'm racked all through.
Unless peace is soon declared, we shall be driven
In the void of women to try Cleisthenes. [4]

CHORUS

Be wise and cover those things with your tunics.
Who knows what kind of person may perceive you? [5]

ATHENIANS

By Zeus, you're right.

SPARTANS

By the two goddesses, [6]
Indeed you are. Let's put our tunics on.

ATHENIANS

Hail O my fellow-sufferers, hail Spartans.

SPARTANS

O honey darling, what a woeful thing!
If they had seen us with our lunging woodies!

ATHENIANS

Tell us then, Spartans, what has brought you here?

SPARTANS

We come to treat of peace.

ATHENIANS

Well spoken there!
And we the same. Let us call out Lysistrata
Since she alone can settle the peace terms.

SPARTANS

Call out Lysistratus [7] too if you don't mind.

CHORUS

No indeed. She hears your voices and she comes.

(Enter LYSISTRATA).

Hail, wonder of all women! Now you must be in turn
Hard, shifting, clear, deceitful, noble, crafty, sweet, and stern.

The foremost men of Hellas, smitten by your fascination,
Have brought their tangled quarrels here for your sole arbitration.

LYSISTRATA

An easy task if the love's raging home-sickness
Doesn't start trying out how well each other
Will serve instead of us. But I'll know at once
If they do. O where's that girl, Reconciliation? [8]
Bring first before me the Spartan delegates,
And see you lift no rude or violent hands--
None of the churlish ways our husbands used.
But lead them courteously, as women should.
And if they grudge fingers, guide them by other methods,
And introduce them with ready tact. The Athenians
Draw by whatever offers you a grip.
Now, Spartans, stay here facing me. Here you,
Athenians. Both hearken to my words.
I am a woman, but I'm not a fool.
And what of natural intelligence I own
Has been filled out with the remembered precepts
My father and the city-elders taught me.
First I reproach you both sides equally
That when at Pylae and Olympia,
At Pytho and the many other shrines
That I could name, you sprinkle from one cup
The altars common to all Hellenes, yet [9]
You wrack Hellenic cities, bloody Hellas
With deaths of her own sons, while yonder clangs
The gathering menace of barbarians. [10]

ATHENIANS

We cannot hold it in much longer now.

LYSISTRATA

Now unto you, O Spartans, do I speak.
Do you forget how your own countryman,
Pericleidas, once came hither suppliant
Before our altars, pale in his purple robes,
Praying for an army when in Messenia
Danger growled, and the Sea-god [11] made earth quaver.
Then with four thousand hoplites Cimon marched
And saved all Sparta. [12] Yet base ingrates now,
You are ravaging the soil of your preservers.

ATHENIANS

By Zeus, they do great wrong, Lysistrata.

SPARTANS

Great wrong, indeed. O! What a luscious wench!

LYSISTRATA

And now I turn to the Athenians.
Have you forgotten too how once the Spartans
In days when you wore slavish tunics, came

And with their spears broke a Thessalian host
And all the partisans of Hippias? [\[13\]](#)
They alone stood by your shoulder on that day.
They freed you, so that for the slave's short skirt
You should wear the trailing cloak of liberty.

SPARTANS

I've never seen a nobler woman anywhere.

ATHENIANS

Nor I one with such prettily jointing hips.

LYSISTRATA

Now, brethren twined with mutual benefactions,
Can you still war, can you suffer such disgrace?
Why not be friends? What is there to prevent you?

SPARTANS

We're agreed, as long as we get this tempting hole.

LYSISTRATA

Which one?

SPARTANS

That one we've wanted to get into,
O for so long.... Pylos, of course. [\[14\]](#)

ATHENIANS

By Poseidon,
Never!

LYSISTRATA

Give it up.

ATHENIANS

Then what will we do?
We need that ticklish place united to us--

LYSISTRATA

Ask for some other lurking-hole in return.

ATHENIANS

Then, ah, we'll choose this snug thing here, Echinus,
Shall we call the nestling spot? And this backside haven,
These desirable twin promontories, the Maliac,
And then of course these Megarean Legs. [\[15\]](#)

SPARTANS

Not that, O surely not that, never that.

LYSISTRATA

Agree! Now what are two legs more or less?

ATHENIANS

I want to strip at once and plough my land.

SPARTANS

And mine I want to fertilize at once.

LYSISTRATA

And so you can, when peace is once declared.
If you mean it, get your allies' heads together
And come to some decision.

ATHENIANS

What allies?
There's no distinction in our politics:
We've risen as one man to this conclusion;
Every ally is jumping-mad to drive it home.

SPARTANS

And ours the same, for sure.

ATHENIANS

The Carystians first! [\[16\]](#)
I'll bet on that.

LYSISTRATA

I agree with all of you.
Now off, and cleanse yourselves for the Acropolis, [\[17\]](#)
For we invite you all in to a supper
From our commissariat baskets. [\[18\]](#) There at table
You will pledge good behavior and uprightness;
Then each man's wife is his to hustle home.

ATHENIANS

Come, as quickly as possible.

SPARTANS

As quick as ye like.
Lead on.

ATHENIANS

O Zeus, quick, quick, lead quickly on.
(They hurry off).

CHORUS.

Broidered stuffs on high I'm heaping,
Fashionable cloaks and sweeping
Trains, not even gold gauds keeping.
Take them all, I pray you, take them all (I do not care)
And deck your children--your daughter, if the basket she's to bear. [\[19\]](#)
Come, everyone of you, come in and take
Of this rich hoard a share.
Nothing is tied so skillfully
But you its seal can break
And plunder all you spy inside.
I've laid out all that I can spare,
And therefore you will see
Nothing unless than I you're sharper-eyed.

If lacking grain a man should be
While his slaves clamor hungrily
And his excessive progeny,
Then I've a handful of grain at home which is always to be had,
And to which in fact a more-than-life-size loaf I'd gladly add.
Then let the poor bring with them bag or sack
And take this store of food. [20]
Manes, my man, I'll tell
To help them all to pack
Their wallets full. But O take care.
I had forgotten; don't intrude,
Or terrified you'll yell.
My dog is hungry too, and bites--beware!

Footnotes:

- [1] Each mina was worth quite a lot. We're talking thousands of dollars.
- [2] A joke about the kinds of pork-barreling and kick-back schemes embedded in Athenian politics and the war effort.
- [3] In the text it says Carystians--apparently their name lent itself to sexual punning. They were also important Athenian allies.
- [4] In other words, in the absence of women, to have a tryst with an actual Athenian attacked for being openly homosexual.
- [5] Ruden notes that the chorus here is warning about a group of individuals who mutilated the Hermae (guardian statues with erect penises) which guarded many homes shortly before the disastrously fated Sicilian expedition in 415 BCE (63, n.140).
- [6] Ruden has "twin gods" (Ruden 63). Either Demeter and Kore, or the Spartan Castor and Pollux.
- [7] Lysistratus is the male version of Lysistrata's name. The Spartans assume a male negotiator will take over.
- [8] Reconciliation, although a female personification, would have been played by a male actor, probably in some kind of exaggerated drag or padded suit.
- [9] Lysistrata here refers to the pan-Hellene competitions of the Olympics (Pisa), Pylaea (Thermopylae) and Pythia (Delphi). These games brought Hellenic city-states together in relatively peaceful competition.
- [10] In other words, remember the Persian Wars!
- [11] Poseidon
- [12] An Athenian general. Lysistrata rearranges history to suit her purposes, as the choruses did with well-known myths earlier. Cimon showed up in Sparta with reinforcements after an earthquake (one of Poseidon's specialties) and a mass rebellion by the Messenian helots (serf-like workers bound to the land). The Spartans suspected his motives and sent him home.
- [13] In 510 BCE, the Spartans had allied with exiled Athenians to fight and defeat the tyrant Hippias and his Thessalian mounted warriors.
- [14] This exchange contains all kinds of allusions to the Spartans' alleged preference for anal intercourse. The city of Pylos was of key strategic importance and had been controlled by Athens since about 425 BCE.
- [15] Another series of sexual puns. One can imagine poor Reconciliation serving as a physical prop with various body parts standing for desirable pieces of territory.
- [16] Important allies of Athens whose name apparently led itself to innuendo.
- [17] Ritual bathing was essential for purification purposes before entering sacred spaces.
- [18] Or "boxes". More innuendo.
- [19] See the note above on women and religious rituals in Athens. The highest honor for a young virgin was to be chosen to bear the basket in the Panathenaea festival in Athens.
- [20] Jokes at the expense of Athenian public relief programs. Public assistance is still called "being on the dole" in England.

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2.6: Section 6

(Some LOUNGERS from the Market with torches approach the Banqueting hall. The PORTER bars their entrance).

1ST MARKET-LOUNGER

Open the door.

PORTER

Here move along.

1ST MARKET-LOUNGER

What's this?

You're sitting down. Shall I singe you with my torch?

That's vulgar! O I couldn't do it ... yet

If it would gratify the audience, [1]

I'll mortify myself.

2ND MARKET-LOUNGER

And I will too.

We'll both be crude and vulgar, yes we will.

PORTER

Be off at once now or you'll be wailing

Dirges for your hair. Get off at once,

And see you don't disturb the Spartan envoys

Just coming out from the splendid feast they've had.

(The banqueters begin to come out).

1ST ATHENIAN

I've never known such a pleasant banquet before,

And what delightful fellows the Spartans are.

When we are warm with wine, how wise we grow.

2ND ATHENIAN

That's only fair, since sober we're such fools:

This is the advice I'd give the Athenians--

See our ambassadors are always drunk.

For when we visit Sparta sober, then

We're on the alert for trickery all the while

So that we miss half of the things they say,

And misinterpret things that were never said,

And then report the muddle back to Athens.

But now we're charmed with each other. They might cap

With the Telamon-catch instead of the Cleitagora, [2]

And we'd applaud and praise them just the same;

We're not too scrupulous in weighing words.

PORTER

Why, here the rascals come again to plague me.

Won't you move on, you sorry loafers there!

MARKET-LOUNGER

Yes, by Zeus, they're already coming out.

SPARTANS

Now honey dearest, please take up your pipe
That I may try a spring and sing my best
In honor of the Athenians and ourselves.

ATHENIANS

Aye, take your pipe. By all the gods, there's nothing
Could glad my heart more than to watch you dance.

SPARTANS.

Mnemosyne, [3]

Let thy fire storm these youngsters,
O tongue with stormy ecstasy
My Muse [4] that knows
Our deeds and theirs, how when at sea
Their navies swooped upon
The Medes [5] at Artemision-- [6]
Gods for their courage, did they strike
Wrenching a triumph from their foes;
While at Thermopylae [7]
Leonidas' [8] army stood: wild-boars they were like
Wild-boars that with fierce threat
Their terrible tusks whet;
The sweat ran streaming down each twisted face,
Glad blossoming in strange petals of death
Panted from mortal breath,
The sweat drenched and their bodies in that place,
For the hurly-burly of Persians glittered more
Than the sands on the shore.

Come, Hunting Girl, [9] and hear my prayer--
You whose arrows whizz in woodlands, come and bless
This peace we swear.
Let us be fenced with age-long amity,
O let this bond stick ever firm through thee
In friendly happiness.
Henceforth no guileful perjury be seen!
O hither, hither O
Thou wildwood queen.

LYSISTRATA

Earth is delighted now, peace is the voice of earth.
Spartans, sort out your wives: Athenians, yours.
Let each catch hands with his wife and dance his joy, [10]
Dance out his thanks, be grateful in music,
And promise reformation with his heels.

ATHENIANS.

O Dancers, forward. Lead out the Graces, [11]
Call Artemis [12] out;
Then her brother, the Dancer of Skies,
That gracious Apollo. [13]
Invoke with a shout
Dionysus out of whose eyes
Breaks fire on the maenads that follow; [14]

And Zeus [15] with his flares of quick lightning, and call,
Happy Hera, [16] Queen of all,
And all the Daimons [17] summon hither to be
Witnesses of our revelry
And of the noble peace we have made,
Aphrodite our aid. [18]
Io Paieon, Io, cry--
For victory, leap!
Attained by me, leap!
Euoi Euoi Euai Euai.

SPARTANS

Piper, give us the music for a new sang.

SPARTANS.

Leaving again lovely lofty Taygetus [19]
Hither O Spartan Muse, hither to greet us,
And with our choric voice to raise
To Amyclean Apollo [20] praise,
And Tyndareus' [21] gallant sons whose days
Along Eurotas' banks merrily pass,
And Athena of the House of Brass. [22]

Now the dance begin;
Dance, making swirl your fringe of wooly skin,
While we join voices
To hymn dear Sparta that rejoices
In a beautiful song,
And loves to see
Dancers tangled beautifully;
For the girls in tumbled ranks
Along Eurotas' banks
Like wanton fillies throng,
Frolicking there
And like Bacchantes shaking the wild air
To comb a giddy laughter through the hair,
Bacchantes that clench thyrsi as they sweep
To the ecstatic leap. [23]

And Helen, child of Leda, [24] come
O holy, nimble, graceful Queen,
Lead the dance, gather your joyous tresses up in bands
And play like a fawn. To madden them, clap your hands,
And sing praise to the warrior goddess templed in our lands,
Her of the House of Brass.

Footnotes:

- [1] Comedic plays often included scenes with slapstick chases and beatings, often involving actors playing slaves.
- [2] Raucous songs sung while drunk about Greek myths.
- [3] The goddess Memory, mother of the Muses.
- [4] Bards traditionally invoked the Muses, goddesses believed to inspire all creative efforts.
- [5] Persians.

- [6] The Athenian navy fought that of Persia off Artemisium in 480 BCE.
 - [7] The Spartans were trapped in this pass, holding off the Persian field army.
 - [8] A famed Spartan general.
 - [9] Artemis, goddess of the hunt.
 - [10] Dance was part of many sacred religious rituals and celebrations.
 - [11] Goddesses typically depicted as dancing.
 - [12] Goddess of the hunt and virgins.
 - [13] God of the sun, archery, and plague.
 - [14] God of wine with a complex mystery cult attached to his worship which focused on him as a figure of resurrection. The maenads were his occasionally frenzied female followers.
 - [15] Head and father of the Olympian gods.
 - [16] Zeus's sister and wife, goddess of marriage.
 - [17] Minor deities, often viewed as the equivalent of guardian angels.
 - [18] Goddess of love.
 - [19] A mountain in Sparta.
 - [20] A shrine was dedicated to Apollo near the city of Sparta.
 - [21] Castor and Polydeuces, twin brothers of Helen, deified heroes.
 - [22] Another temple in Sparta.
 - [23] Female followers of Dionysus who engaged in ecstatic dancing. The *thyrsi* were sacred wands or staffs.
 - [24] Helen was supposedly born of Leda's coupling with Zeus in the form of a swan.
-

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Viewing Guide for Spike Lee's Chi-Raq

CHI-RAQ VIEWING GUIDE:

Introduction:

Spike Lee debuted *Chi-Raq* in 2015, to mixed reviews. Lee's film adapted *Lysistrata* and blended elements of tragic and comedic plays to address the problem of gun violence in Chicagoland, itself a symptom of other underlying issues including racial inequality, economic under-development, government policies, the "war on drugs," mass incarceration, the military-industrial complex in the United States, and more. Euripides' *Lysistrata* mixed everyday Greek speech and comedic banter with choruses who subverted the elevated Greek of the tragic plays while commenting on events. *Lysistrata*'s central protagonists are ordinary and far from perfect, so too with the central characters of *Chi-Raq*: Cyclops, Indigo, Lysistrata, Miss Helen Worthy, the mourning Irene, mother of Patti, and the rapper Demetrius Dupree (alias Chi-Raq).

In *Chi-Raq*, the city is divided into two rival gangs, the Trojans (orange, Troy-town), led by Cyclops, and the Spartans (purple, Sparta-South), led by Chi-Raq. *Chiraq*'s narrator, Dolomedes (played by Samuel Jackson), is dressed in formal suits and provides commentary on the action, thus combining the function of the tragic chorus (whose comments tended to reaffirm social customs) with that of the comedic chorus (which suggested innovative solutions). The tone of *Chi-Raq* partakes of both tragedy and comedy, alternating between the tragic death of Patti from stray gunfire to comedic send ups of male and female gender roles and relationships. The film could be viewed as a "comedy," in that it ends with a truce and promise of assistance and personal redemption, but also as a tragedy, in that one of the central characters must go to prison to "atone" for Patti's death. The powerful language of rap is employed throughout the film as a modern counterpoint to Greek verse, and instead of the gods and Greek oratory, we have urban Christianity and powerful sermons by Rev. Mike Corridan.

Questions to bear in mind while viewing the film are listed below.

Assignment:

Please post your answer to one of these questions to the Chiraq Discussion Forum linked on the school LMS. Try for between 100-200 words, think of using visual and verbal evidence and rich explanation of it to support your answer, and make sure you are answering your chosen question in a different way than your classmates by reading through the answers first. Be prepared to discuss the questions you answered in class and to defend your answer with evidence.

Pay close attention to the opening credits and lyrics. How does Spike Lee set the scene? What image of Chicago is he painting and why?

Throughout the film, how do the music and lyrics enrich the meaning or comment on the plot/action?

What event sparks Lysistrata's protest? Why does it spark protest?

What other factors does Spike Lee highlight as helping to create the circumstances for gun violence to flourish?

Why was the world rocked by the gun violence at Sandy Hook and other schools and not by the annual death rate by gun violence in Chicago, according to Spike Lee?

Which protesters inspired Lysistrata's own actions?

At about one-half hour into the film, Spike Lee rewrites the famous oath scene from *Lysistrata*. Do the changes work for you within the context of the film? Why/why not?

About two minutes later, we have Dolomedes at the barber shop. What sentiments and opinions are expressed there?

At Patti's funeral, the Reverend gives a powerful speech. According to him, what factors led to Patti's death? To what historical events and figures does he refer and why?

What other elements of life in Chiraq does Lee address before we meet General King Kong? What problems exist and does he offer any solutions?

What is Spike Lee trying to say in the scene where Lysistrata confronts General King Kong? This is a complex and disturbing scene filled with visual symbolism and verbal allusions and outright slurs.

Given the complex and often disturbing nature of police and community relations in the Chicagoland area, what do we make of Spike Lee's treatment of the reaction of the National Guard, SWAT teams and local police (and the fictional white mayor of Chicago) to Lysistrata's and her female army's occupation of the armory?

What is the effect of the strike on the Knights of Euphrates? Note the character of Oedipus.

How does political protest intersect with gender relationships in *Chi-Raq*? Is this comparable to what occurs in *Lysistrata* or is it very different?

How does political protest intersect with power relationships in *Chi-Raq*? Is this comparable to what occurs in *Lysistrata* or is it very different?

How does political protest intersect with race relationships in *Chi-Raq*? Is this comparable to what occurs in *Lysistrata* or is it very different?

What factors and problems emerge in the bargaining process for peace?

At about 1 hr and 50 minutes, there is a key negotiation scene. What do the inhabitants of Chiraq see as the solution to their problems? What do they need as a community according to Spike Lee (he is not from Chicago, but grew up in Brooklyn, New York)?

Do the mothers dressed in white with photographs of their dead children evoke Euripides' *The Trojan Women* or a tragic Greek chorus (or perhaps the Furies)? Is their silence powerful or have they been robbed of speech? How does their protest compare to and intersect with that of Lysistrata and her female supporters?

Do we find the ending of this film satisfying or disturbing? Why/how?

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Extension Activities- Lysistrata in an Age of Protest

Extension Activities: *Lysistrata* in an Age of Protest

Research and Analysis Assignment Option One:

Have students research the history of sex strikes around the world and in different time periods.

Are sex strikes effective as a tactic or are other tactics employed in *Lysistrata* and other historical protests more effective? Why/why not?

Research and Analysis Assignment Option Two:

Have students research the role of women and other marginalized groups as leaders and participants in recent and past protests.

Examples could include the marches in support of temperance, the abolition of slavery, voting rights, civil rights, the Arab Spring, the Black Lives Matter movement, the recent Women's Marches, the LGBTQ+ movement, the #MeToo movement.

To what extent did women and/or other non-dominant groups assume leadership roles or participate in these movements?

What tactics did these movements use and which were most effective?

What kinds of rhetoric and visual symbols were employed by these movements? Why were they chosen?

What was the response of authorities and those in power to these movements and why?

Evaluative Assignment Option One:

Research various adaptations and performances of *Lysistrata* (for example, try YouTube for local adaptations performed and recorded).

Evaluate the performance you chose.

How do producers try to make this play "relevant"?

Was the performance or adaptation effective or was *Lysistrata's* essential message lost in translation? This requires examining what *Lysistrata's* central message is.

What difference does casting make? (Ancient Greek performances would have had male actors playing all the roles before an almost exclusively male audience).

Creative Assignment Option One:

Rewrite a portion of *Lysistrata* and set it in a different time and place.

How does changing the context of the play change the meaning of specific passages?

What choices did you have to make as an author?

Creative Assignment Option Two:

Rehearse with your assigned group your assigned scene from *Lysistrata*. Share it with the class by Flipgrid or YouTube.

How do casting, context, costuming, and delivery of lines influence your classmates' experience of your scene? Would you perform this differently for an audience with your guardians or other adults you admire present? Why/why not?

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